

Talk Shows, Populism, and the Far Right

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Abstract

Broadcast media firms influence political competition by deciding which actors gain access to prominent public platforms. This paper studies how appearances by different parties on political talk shows shape party support and economic expectations, with particular attention to populist parties and the far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD). It combines the newly constructed Talkshow Dataset of Germany (TDOG), covering more than 6,000 political talk-show episodes from 1998 to 2025, with more than 3.3 million daily forsa survey responses, comparing respondents interviewed on the broadcast day with respondents interviewed on the following day.

I first show that talk-show access is not distributed proportionally to party support: the AfD is underrepresented after 2013, but not uniquely so. I then estimate immediate effects of party appearances on vote intention. Talk-show appearances increase support for the appearing party by about 0.14 percentage points on average, with the largest party-specific effect estimated for the AfD. AfD and Left appearances also shift economic expectations in a pessimistic direction, and respondents holding pessimistic expectations are substantially more likely to support either party. This alignment is consistent with a broader economic-grievance channel. Income, age, and municipality-size heterogeneity provide supporting context on the constituencies most responsive to these appearances rather than a formal mediation test. The results provide high-frequency evidence that political visibility can generate immediate, heterogeneous shifts in public opinion, while also showing that media gatekeeping decouples platform access from electoral strength.

Keywords: Media effects; media gatekeeping; political talk shows; far-right parties; populism; electoral behavior; economic expectations

JEL Codes: D72; D83; L82; P16

1 Introduction

Mass media occupy a central gatekeeping role in democratic politics. By deciding which political actors receive access to prominent public platforms, broadcasters shape not only what citizens hear about, but also who is seen as a legitimate participant in political competition. This role has become especially contested with the rise of populist and far-right parties. Supporters of platforming argue that democratic debate requires exposure and confrontation; critics worry that mainstream visibility normalizes radical actors, amplifies their grievances, and helps them convert attention into electoral support. Whether mainstream media access contributes to the success of populist and far-right parties has therefore become a central question in contemporary democracies.

A large political-economy literature shows that media environments can affect political behavior, including political knowledge, issue salience, ideological beliefs, polarization, and electoral outcomes (DellaVigna and Kaplan, 2007; Enikolopov, Petrova, and Zhuravskaya, 2011; Martin and Yurukoglu, 2017). Yet the evidence on high-profile political broadcasts is more mixed. Candidate visibility itself can matter (Caprini, 2023), and talk-show or infotainment formats can shape evaluations of politicians, especially among less politically informed viewers (Baum, 2005; Boukes and Boomgaarden, 2016). At the same time, recent evidence finds limited effects of televised debates on vote choice (Le Pennec and Pons, 2023). This leaves open whether access to prominent mainstream media platforms generates shifts in party support and, if so, how political actors convert such visibility into support.

Political talk shows are a particularly useful setting for studying these questions. In one form or another, they are a common feature of political communication across democracies. They are recurring, journalistically curated forums in which broadcasters decide who is invited, which issues are discussed, and which political conflicts are staged before a mass audience. Unlike paid advertising or party-controlled communication, access is allocated by media organizations. In Germany, flagship programs such as *Anne Will* reached around four million viewers in strong years. Their importance also extends beyond audience size: through guest selection, topic choice, framing, and moderator questioning, talk shows allocate political attention and signal which actors are treated as legitimate participants in public debate (McCombs and Shaw, 1972; Cobb and Elder, 1971; van der Pas, 2022). I therefore use this setting to study two related questions: first, how talk shows act as gatekeepers by allocating platform access across parties; and second, whether the visibility they allocate is consequential for public opinion.

This paper studies these questions using political talk shows in Germany between 1998 and 2025. For this purpose, I construct the Talkshow Dataset of Germany (TDOG), a new dataset covering more than 6,000 political talk-show episodes, and combine it with more than 3.3 million daily forsa survey responses.

I first examine the gatekeeping dimension by comparing each party’s share of talk-show appearances with its contemporaneous share of vote intention. Access is clearly not proportional to public support. The AfD is underrepresented relative to its support after entering national party competition, but this pattern is not unique to the AfD. Government participation also tends to coincide with greater visibility for some parties, particularly smaller coalition partners, although the pattern is not uniform. More generally, much of the movement in representation gaps reflects changes in vote-intention shares against comparatively smoother appearance shares rather than equally large changes in allocated talk-show access. These patterns show that editorial gatekeeping systematically

decouples platform access from electoral strength.

I then ask whether this allocated visibility is consequential for public opinion. The empirical design compares respondents interviewed on the day of a broadcast with respondents interviewed on the following day. An appearance increases support for the appearing party by about 0.14 percentage points on average. The corresponding average effect on being named the party best able to solve Germany's problems is about 0.12 points. These similar averages mask different party-specific patterns: the largest support estimate is for the AfD, while the FDP and SPD estimates are statistically precise; perceived competence rises most clearly for the AfD, CDU/CSU, and the Left. Average pre-treatment estimates are generally small, although isolated party- and model-specific leads warrant a cautious timing interpretation.

To explore how political actors may convert visibility into support, I examine economic expectations. Economic pessimism is not itself a defining feature of populism, but the people-versus-elite logic is compatible with narratives of failure, decline, and crisis, in which political or economic problems become evidence that established elites are failing ordinary citizens. This mirrors Moffitt (2015)'s notion of the *performance of crisis*, whereby political actors connect individual failures into a broader narrative of crisis and assign responsibility to elites. Related work finds particularly pronounced societal pessimism among supporters of the populist radical right and, to a lesser extent, the radical left (Steenvoorden and Harteveld, 2018). Economic expectations therefore provide a way to assess whether talk-show visibility changes perceptions of the broader state of the country, not only party support. Empirically, AfD and Left appearances are followed by more pessimistic expectations, and respondents expecting economic deterioration are substantially more likely to support either party, conditional on interview date and respondent characteristics. The absence of a corresponding aggregate effect for opposition parties indicates that this is not an opposition phenomenon per se. Taken together, these findings are consistent with a grievance-alignment channel. Because expectations and vote intentions are measured contemporaneously, the second relationship is not interpreted causally and the analysis does not identify formal mediation. Heterogeneity by income, age, and municipality size provides additional context, with both parties gaining most clearly among low-income respondents.

I also examine two additional mechanisms. First, I test whether first or early appearances by politicians have especially large effects, because such appearances should be most informative if voters learn that a party has a new or unexpected type of representative in its ranks. The evidence does not reveal a clear pattern across parties that would support politician novelty as a general mechanism. Second, I test whether the estimated effects mainly come from respondents who had previously voted for the appearing party. Such a pattern would suggest reinforcement: talk-show appearances would primarily reactivate existing supporters rather than move other voters. The results provide little evidence for this mechanism as a general explanation. Overall, they point more toward party-specific persuasion and activation among broader voter groups than toward simple reinforcement among previous own-party voters.

The paper contributes to three literatures. First, it contributes to research on media effects and political persuasion by studying recurring, journalistically curated broadcast exposure. Second, it contributes to work on media gatekeeping and political representation by treating visibility as an allocated political resource rather than a reflection of party strength. Third, it contributes to research on populism and the far right by showing when platform access translates into political support and by identifying economic anxiety as a potential mechanism. Section 2 provides the institutional background and develops the argument linking populist communication, media gatekeeping, and economic expectations. Section 3 introduces TDOG and the forsa data. Section 4 outlines the empirical strategy. Section 5 presents the results, heterogeneity analyses, and mechanism

checks. Section 6 concludes.

2 Institutional Setting and Conceptual Framework

2.1 The Platforming Dilemma and Media Gatekeeping

Political talk shows are not a peculiarity of the German media system. Political interview and discussion formats recur across a wide range of democracies, even though their precise institutional forms differ. A comparative content analysis, for example, studies twelve weekly political talk shows in six Western democracies—Switzerland, Germany, France, Italy, the United Kingdom, and the United States—while a more recent survey measures political talk-show use among 26,000 respondents in eighteen democracies (Ernst et al., 2019; Schemer et al., 2024). These studies do not imply that formats or audiences are identical across countries, but they show that televised political discussion is a genuinely cross-national arena of political communication. Audience figures provide a sense of scale, although they are not directly comparable across media systems: in the United States, *Meet the Press* averaged about 2.5 million viewers in 2025; in France, *C dans l'air* drew about 1.7 million viewers for a high-performing episode reported by France Télévisions; and in Germany, *Anne Will* averaged more than 4.1 million viewers in its record year 2021 (NBC News, 2026; France Télévisions, 2017; Norddeutscher Rundfunk, 2023).

The central institutional feature of these formats is *gatekeeping*. In the classic formulation, media gatekeepers reduce a much larger set of possible events, actors, and messages to the comparatively small set that reaches an audience (White, 1950). Political communication research shows that this selection is consequential: which party messages enter media coverage depends on journalistic news values and can also vary systematically across outlets (Haselmayer et al., 2017). In political talk shows, gatekeeping is especially visible because editorial teams choose the topic, allocate a scarce number of seats, decide which politicians and other actors receive access, and determine the constellation in which they meet. Unlike paid advertising or party-controlled communication, parties cannot simply purchase this access. An invitation therefore combines visibility, scrutiny, and *legitimation*: it provides access to a mass audience, exposes the guest to journalistic questioning and political opponents, and simultaneously treats the actor as sufficiently relevant to participate in a prominent mainstream political forum.

This creates a platforming dilemma. Inviting controversial actors can facilitate democratic scrutiny by confronting their claims, exposing them to counterarguments, and allowing citizens to evaluate them directly. At the same time, the invitation itself expands their reach and can confer mainstream visibility and legitimation. The tension is particularly salient for populist and far-right actors, which may attack mainstream media as part of an allegedly detached or corrupt elite while simultaneously benefiting from access to those same institutions. Recent work on far-right platforming emphasizes the risk that even critical or adversarial interviews can amplify and normalize actors who would otherwise have less access to mainstream audiences, while other research underlines that visibility can also expose politicians to effective criticism (Thompson and Sengul, 2025; Bolet and Foos, 2025; Hopmann, Vliegenthart, de Vreese, and Albæk, 2010; Murphy and Devine, 2020). At the normative level, this tension echoes Popper's paradox of tolerance: an open society values broad contestation, yet unrestricted tolerance can undermine the conditions that sustain openness itself (Popper, 1945). Applied to media gatekeeping, the analogy does not imply a general rule of exclusion; it highlights why decisions about

platform access become especially consequential when actors challenge liberal-democratic norms.

The consequences of platform access are therefore theoretically ambiguous. An appearance may increase familiarity, make a party's arguments more salient, or signal political relevance, but it may also expose politicians to positions or performances that viewers dislike. This motivates two related questions. First, how do political talk shows exercise gatekeeping power—that is, which parties receive access to prominent platforms? Second, is the visibility allocated through this gatekeeping consequential for public opinion? The German setting is particularly useful for studying both dimensions because frequent nationally visible broadcasts can be linked to unusually rich daily survey data.

2.2 Populism, Crisis, and Economic Expectations

I follow the ideational approach and define populism as a thin-centered ideology that portrays politics as a moral conflict between a virtuous and homogeneous people and a corrupt elite and holds that politics should express the general will of the people (Mudde, 2004; Guriev and Papaioannou, 2022). This distinguishes populism from ordinary opposition or criticism of incumbent governments: its defining feature is the moralized people-versus-elite distinction. Because populism is thin-centered, it is typically combined with a broader host ideology. Left-wing variants commonly connect the people–elite distinction to economic inequality, redistribution, and the political influence of wealthy individuals or corporations. Right-wing variants more often combine anti-elitism with nationalism, nativism, cultural conservatism, and opposition to immigration (Mudde, 2004; Mudde and Rovira Kaltwasser, 2013; Salmela and von Scheve, 2018). The populist radical right additionally combines populism with nativism and authoritarianism (Mudde, 2007).

This framework also suggests a broader way in which political actors may use media access. Parties compete not only over evaluations of themselves but also over citizens' interpretations of political and economic conditions. Economic pessimism is not part of the definition of populism, and negative economic rhetoric is not unique to populist parties. Nevertheless, a people-versus-elite framework is particularly compatible with narratives of failure, decline, and crisis, in which individual political or economic problems are connected and attributed to the failure of established elites. Moffitt (2015) describes this as the *performance of crisis*: political actors can actively construct a sense of crisis by linking otherwise separate developments, identifying responsible elites or threatening out-groups, and presenting political change as necessary. Comparative research on political talk shows likewise treats crisis rhetoric as an important component of populist communication (Ernst et al., 2019).

Political actors therefore have strategic incentives to influence how citizens assess the economy and its future trajectory. Evidence from party discourse shows that challenger parties can shift subjective evaluations of national economic performance by making economic problems more salient, whereas incumbents are more constrained by observed economic conditions (Pardos-Prado and Sagarzazu, 2016). More generally, parties outside government can emphasize failure and deterioration without simultaneously defending the incumbent record (Otjes and Louwerse, 2021). The relevant predictions are consequently not that every appearance should generate pessimism or that such effects are uniquely populist. Rather, both the direction and magnitude of changes in economic expectations may vary across parties, government status, and political or economic contexts over time. For populist actors in particular, shifts in broader perceptions of decline or crisis

are theoretically important because they can make the people-versus-elite conflict more resonant. Related work documents especially pronounced societal pessimism among supporters of the populist radical right and, to a lesser extent, the radical left (Steenvoorden and Harteveld, 2018).

I therefore examine two immediate consequences of platform access. The first is support for the appearing party. Visibility can increase familiarity, salience, or perceived competence, but scrutiny and counterargument make the sign of the effect theoretically ambiguous. The second is economic expectations. A shift in expectations after an appearance would indicate that political visibility can affect perceptions of the broader state and trajectory of the country rather than only short-run party evaluations. Because the analysis does not code the content of every appearance, it cannot identify which statements or rhetorical frames produce such changes. I additionally examine heterogeneity across respondent characteristics to characterize where estimated effects are concentrated, without treating these analyses as tests of sharply specified *ex ante* demographic predictions.

2.3 Populism in the German Party System

Germany is a parliamentary multiparty democracy with proportional representation and coalition governments. The analysis focuses on six party families that held seats in the Bundestag during the observation period: CDU/CSU, SPD, the Greens, FDP, Die Linke, and the AfD (Bundeswahlleiterin, 2025; Bundeszentrale für politische Bildung, 2026). Appendix Section A.1 provides brief descriptions of these parties, and Appendix Table A1 documents their periods of participation in federal government.

Within this party system, the AfD represents the clearest case of a populist radical-right party. Its communication combines criticism of political and media elites with nationalism, opposition to immigration, Euroscepticism, cultural conservatism, and law-and-order appeals. Die Linke provides an importantly different comparison. It is clearly located on the economic left, while its classification as populist depends more strongly on period, actor, and measurement approach. Where it employs populist communication, the people–elite distinction is more commonly embedded in narratives about inequality, redistribution, corporations, wealthy individuals, and economic power.

External classifications support this distinction. The PopuList and CHES identify the AfD as the clearer populist far-right case, while Die Linke occupies a more ambiguous position with respect to populism. Text-based evidence from PopBERT likewise finds particularly strong right-wing and anti-elite populist rhetoric for the AfD and more left-wing populist language for Die Linke (Rooduijn et al., 2024; The PopuList, 2026; Rovny, Polk, Bakker, Hooghe, Jolly, Marks, Steenbergen, and Vachudova, 2025; Erhard, Hanke, Remer, Falenska, and Heiberger, 2025). I therefore treat the AfD as a populist far-right party and Die Linke more cautiously as a left-wing party with important populist elements. The remaining parties provide comparisons from the center-right, center-left, green, and liberal parts of the party system.

2.4 Political Talk Shows and Gatekeeping in Germany

The most important German political talk shows are broadcast by the public-service broadcasters ARD and ZDF, which occupy a prominent position in the German media system. German broadcasting law assigns public-service broadcasting a role in individual and public opinion formation and requires the provision of information, education, culture,

and entertainment (Medienstaatsvertrag, 2020). Political talk shows became a stable feature of prime-time and late-evening political television from the late 1990s onward and provide recurring forums in which politicians, journalists, experts, and other public figures debate current issues before national audiences.

The formats studied here are both frequent and highly visible. The programs covered by TDOG account for more than 7,000 hours of broadcasting since 1998. *Anne Will*, for example, averaged more than 4.1 million viewers in 2021, with a 15.2 percent audience share (Norddeutscher Rundfunk, 2023). Survey evidence points in the same direction: in a February 2025 YouGov survey, 60 percent of respondents reported watching political talk shows at least occasionally; among them, about one third said they watch such programs rather or very frequently (YouGov, 2025). Existing research likewise describes German political talk shows as important arenas of political communication in which guest selection determines which actors and perspectives receive visibility (Fröhlich and Hillje, 2020; Gründler, Potrafke, and Wochner, 2024; Myrczik, Bowen, Franke, Täuber, and Kessler, 2022).

Access to these programs is an explicitly editorial decision. Parties do not purchase appearances or receive airtime mechanically according to electoral support. The ARD states that editorial teams select guests according to journalistic criteria rather than party-proportional rules (ARD, 2026). Topic relevance, political importance, conflict, expertise, and availability therefore enter the gatekeeping process. This selection normally takes place before the broadcast rather than on the broadcast day. A detailed account of German political talk-show production describes the topic as typically being set about a week before airtime, absent breaking news, after which editors build the desired guest constellation (Ehrenberg, 2014). Final lineups are also commonly public before broadcast: for *Caren Miosga*, a contemporary account describes the announcement of the title and invited guests two days before the Sunday broadcast as the usual procedure, while ARD program notices for *Hart aber fair* provide full guest lists several days before Monday broadcasts (Peitz, 2026; ARD Das Erste, 2026). Breaking news can still lead to late changes, but the usual production process makes platform access the outcome of advance editorial gatekeeping rather than a same-day mechanical response to survey support.

The issue has become especially salient with the rise of the AfD. German journalists and broadcasters have repeatedly debated whether and under what conditions AfD representatives should be invited to political interviews and talk shows. One position emphasizes the journalistic responsibility to confront a nationally relevant parliamentary party; another warns that live formats may amplify provocative or misleading claims while providing valuable mainstream visibility (Deutschlandfunk, 2025). The controversy is a concrete instance of the platforming dilemma described above: scrutiny and exposure are generated by the same invitation.

The paper does not take a normative position on how much airtime particular parties should receive or assume that invitations necessarily benefit them. Instead, the German case makes it possible to observe both sides of the gatekeeping process at high frequency: which parties receive access and what happens to public opinion after that access is used. The next section introduces the Talkshow Dataset of Germany and the daily forsa surveys used to measure these two dimensions.

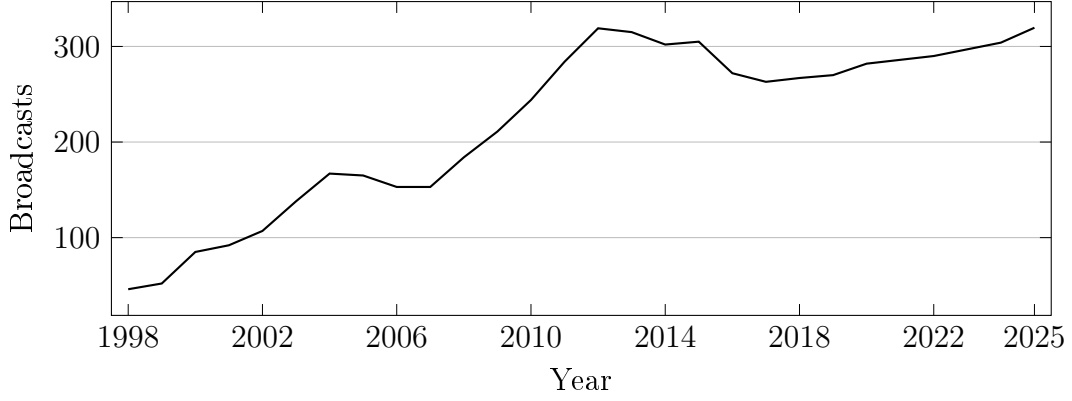


Figure 1: Talk-show broadcasts by year. *Note:* The 2025 value is seasonally projected from the complete first half of 2025 using the mean historical ratio of second-half to first-half broadcasts in 1998–2024.

2025. Broadcast volume rises from fewer than 100 annual broadcasts in the late 1990s and early 2000s to roughly 300 broadcasts per year in the 2010s and early 2020s. Because the archive covers only part of the second half of 2025, the final point is seasonally projected from the complete first half of that year; the implied annual total is approximately 320 broadcasts. Over the sample period, political talk shows thus develop into a regular and institutionalized arena of political visibility.

Appendix Figure A2 shows how party shares of talk-show appearances evolve over time. Visibility differs substantially across parties, but the annual appearance shares are relatively persistent compared with the movement in public support examined below. Access is also highly concentrated across individuals: some politicians and commentators appear repeatedly, while many others appear only rarely. Appendix Figure A3 illustrates this concentration among the most frequent guests.

To assess whether this visibility is proportional to public support, I compare each party’s annual share of major-party talk-show appearances with its annual share of major-party vote intention in the forsa data. For party p in year t , I define

$$\text{Representation gap}_{pt} = 100 \left(\frac{\text{appearances}_{pt}}{\sum_p \text{appearances}_{pt}} - \frac{\overline{\text{vote intention}_{pt}}}{\sum_p \overline{\text{vote intention}_{pt}}} \right).$$

A value of zero indicates proportional representation relative to support, positive values indicate overrepresentation in talk-show appearances, and negative values indicate underrepresentation. Because both components are shares within the same set of parties, the gaps sum to zero across parties within each year: when one party receives less visibility than its support share would imply, another party necessarily receives more. The annual aggregation smooths the noisier monthly and quarterly patterns and makes persistent party-specific deviations from proportional visibility easier to see. The figure therefore provides a descriptive benchmark for assessing which parties receive more or less talk-show access than their level of public support would suggest.

Figure 2 shows three broad patterns. First, the smaller established parties generally receive at least their proportional share of talk-show visibility and are often overrepresented relative to their vote-intention shares; the AfD is the clear exception, remaining underrepresented for much of the period after its entry into national party competition. Second, government participation tends to be associated with greater talk-show visibility, particularly for smaller coalition partners. Third, the representation gaps reflect not only

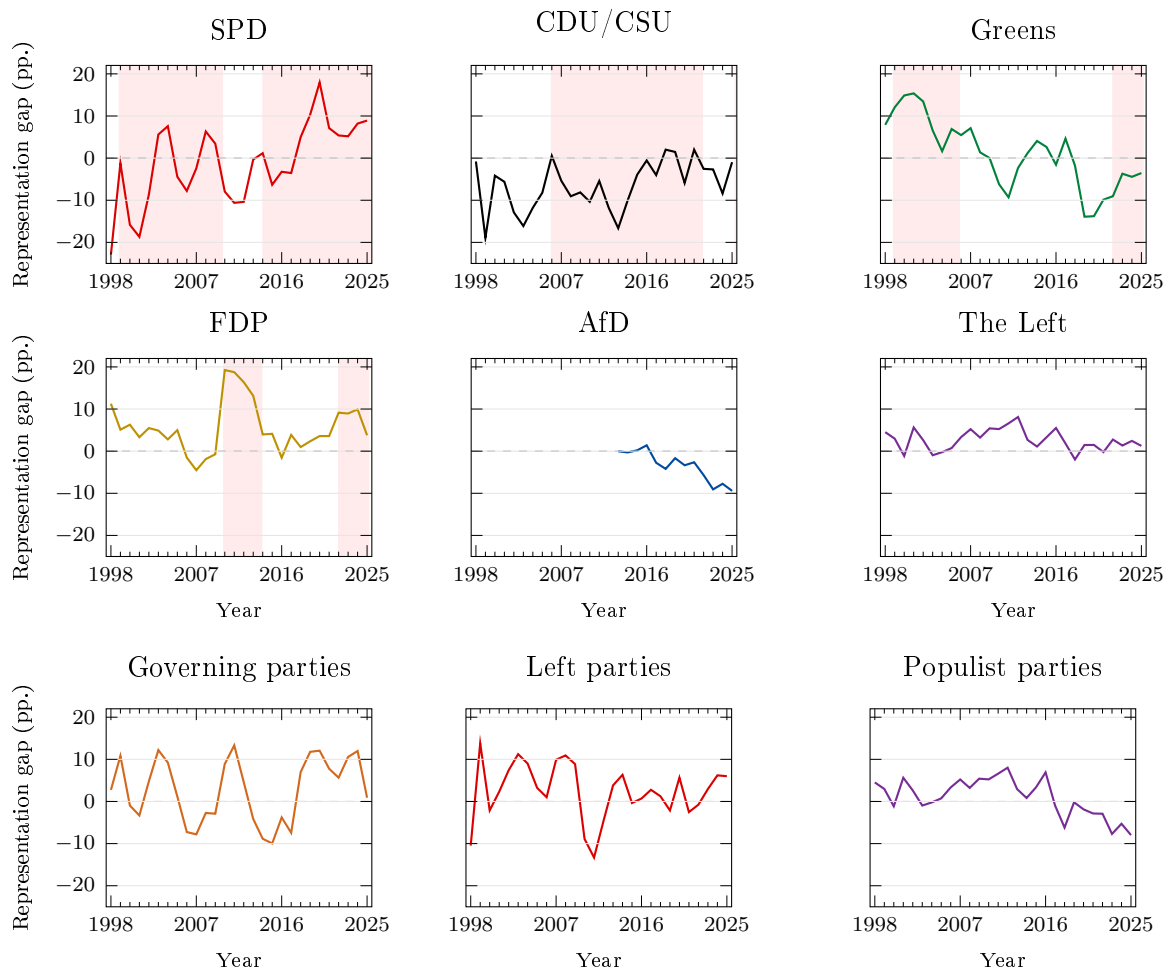


Figure 2: Annual representation gaps in talk-show visibility. For each party or group, the gap is its share of major-party appearances minus its share of major-party vote intentions, in percentage points. In the six party panels, light red shading marks periods of federal-government participation; AfD values are shown from 2013 onward. Governing-party status in the group panel is coded on the exact survey or broadcast date. Left parties comprise SPD, the Greens, and The Left; populist parties are operationalized as AfD and The Left. Opposition, right, and centre group panels are omitted because they are the exact negative counterparts of government, left, and populist parties, respectively.

editorial changes in access but also movements in public support. Appearance shares are comparatively sticky over time, while vote-intention shares move more strongly over longer horizons, so a substantial part of the movement in the gaps comes from changing polls against a smoother allocation of talk-show appearances. Taken together, the patterns underline that talk-show gatekeeping does not mechanically track electoral strength.

Aggregating parties into broader groups makes the allocation pattern more transparent. Across the full period, governing parties receive 56.98 percent of observed party-date appearances, compared with a proportional benchmark of 53.73 percent, yielding a pooled representation gap of 3.25 percentage points. The unweighted mean of the annual gaps is 2.72 percentage points, and governing parties are overrepresented in 17 of the 28 sample years. Figure 2 also shows that this is not a universal incumbency premium: governing parties are underrepresented in several stretches, particularly in the mid-2000s and

mid-2010s, before showing positive gaps from 2018 through 2024. Left parties are over-represented on average (pooled gap: 2.55 percentage points), whereas the much smaller pooled gap for AfD and The Left together (0.30 percentage points) conceals a marked reversal from overrepresentation before 2017 to underrepresentation in most subsequent years. These patterns are descriptive; moreover, the latter grouping is an explicit operationalization rather than a claim that the AfD and The Left are substantively identical.

3.3 Survey Data: forsa (1998–2025)

I merge TDOG with daily repeated cross-sectional survey data from forsa covering 1998–2025. The forsa survey is conducted continuously on weekdays, usually Monday to Friday, with roughly 500 respondents interviewed per survey day. This high-frequency structure makes it possible to match party-specific talk-show appearances to short-run changes in reported party support within narrow event windows. The harmonized survey file contains 3,353,527 individual observations with a non-missing federal vote-intention measure.

The survey provides daily information on vote intentions, past vote, and a range of socio-economic characteristics, including age, gender, education, income, region, and municipality size. In addition, respondents are asked about their expectations for Germany’s economic situation. This item is part of the regular survey instrument and is therefore available for the full main sample rather than only for a special subsample. Respondents can state whether they expect the economic situation to improve, worsen, or remain unchanged. I use these responses to examine whether talk-show appearances also shift broader economic expectations, in addition to reported party support.

Table 2 describes the exact estimation sample used by the preferred main specification and reports a compact balance diagnostic for the two days used in the identifying comparison. After deduplicating respondents across parties and appearance windows, the sample contains 1,963,931 distinct survey respondents, who contribute 5,377,544 respondent–event observations to the stacked analysis. The descriptive columns count each original respondent once.

Table 2: Respondent characteristics and covariate balance

Characteristic	Category	Main-sample N	Percent/value	Talk-show day	Next day	Std. difference
Sample	Unique respondents	1,963,931	100.00	–	–	–
	Respondent–event observations	5,377,544	–	–	–	–
Survey years	Range	1,963,931	1998–2025	–	–	–
Age	Mean (SD)	1,963,931	52.57 (17.20)	53.224	53.297	0.004
	18–44	660,604	33.64	31.868	31.954	0.002
	45–59	570,163	29.03	29.337	29.091	-0.005
	60+	733,164	37.33	38.795	38.956	0.003
Gender	Men	974,711	49.63	50.037	50.072	0.001
	Women	989,138	50.37	49.957	49.922	-0.001
	Other/unclear	82	< 0.01	0.006	0.006	0.000
Education	Lower/basic schooling	956,161	48.69	47.864	47.725	-0.003
	Upper secondary	430,568	21.92	22.101	22.084	0.000
	Tertiary	525,967	26.78	27.364	27.557	0.004
	Other/unclear/student	51,235	2.61	2.671	2.635	-0.002
Household income	Below 1,500 EUR	298,644	15.21	14.491	14.483	0.000
	1,500–2,500 EUR	432,423	22.02	21.434	21.463	0.001
	2,500–4,000 EUR	470,772	23.97	24.073	24.121	0.001
	4,000+ EUR	436,169	22.21	23.511	23.504	0.000
	Other/unclear	325,923	16.60	16.491	16.428	-0.002
Region	West	1,633,810	83.19	83.442	83.464	0.001
	East	330,121	16.81	16.558	16.536	-0.001
Municipality size	Small: 1–19,999	719,051	36.61	36.395	36.412	0.000
	Medium: 20,000–99,999	748,854	38.13	38.128	38.001	-0.003
	Large: 100,000+	258,576	13.17	13.095	13.180	0.003
	Other/unclear	237,450	12.09	12.382	12.407	0.001
Previous vote	Focal party	–	–	13.406	13.403	0.000

Notes: The main-sample columns describe the 1,963,931 unique respondents used by the preferred overlap specification with co-presence controls, counting each original forsa respondent once. These respondents contribute 5,377,544 respondent–event observations because the same survey interview can enter multiple appearance windows. Descriptive counts and percentages are unweighted across the unique-respondent sample; “Other/unclear” categories are retained because they enter the regressions as explicit control categories. The final three columns use the complete stacked estimation sample and compare respondent composition on the talk-show day and the next day. They give each party equal total weight and, within parties, each event-day cell equal weight. Day-specific values are not reported for the sample-count and survey-year rows; the main-sample value for previous vote is not defined because the focal party varies across stacked event windows. Standardized differences divide the day-to-day mean difference by the pooled standard deviation; absolute values below 0.10 are conventionally regarded as small. Significance tests are not reported because the very large stacked sample would make substantively negligible differences statistically significant.

4 Empirical Strategy

4.1 Main model

The empirical strategy links party-specific talk-show visibility to high-frequency changes in vote intention. The forsa data do not record whether an individual respondent watched a particular broadcast, so I do not estimate an average treatment effect among viewers. For the question studied here, this is a feature rather than a limitation of the design. The politically relevant estimand is the population-level effect of a party appearance: after a party receives a prominent national talk-show platform, how much does its support change in the survey population? The reduced-form estimate captures the overall public-opinion response to the appearance, including direct exposure as well as any indirect diffusion through subsequent discussion, media coverage, or interpersonal communication. It therefore estimates the quantity of substantive interest: how much a talk-show appearance benefits or harms a party in aggregate, rather than how strongly it affects the subset of citizens who watched the program.

For each appearance by party p , indexed by event window g , I construct a two-day comparison. Respondents interviewed on the broadcast day associated with g form the pre/reference group, and respondents interviewed on the following day form the post-broadcast group. This timing is substantively motivated by the broadcast schedule: political talk shows air in the evening, while forsa interviews on the same calendar day are expected to take place predominantly before the broadcast. The identifying comparison is therefore the change from the pre-broadcast survey day to the first post-broadcast survey day.

The choice of a one-day horizon is deliberate. Longer windows would increase sample size but would also make it harder to separate the appearance from subsequent political news, additional media coverage, and other talk-show invitations. The one-day comparison instead asks whether support moves immediately after a highly visible party appearance. This is the most transparent test of short-run talk-show effects.

Talk shows often include politicians from several parties in the same episode. The main estimates therefore include co-presence controls, defined as interactions between the post indicator and indicators for whether each other major party appeared in the same episode. The coefficient on the focal party's post indicator captures the immediate response to that party's appearance, holding constant the post effects associated with the simultaneous presence of other major parties.

The main outcome is support for the appearing party, measured as a percentage-point indicator for whether a respondent reports vote intention for that party. I estimate the equations for the six parties jointly as a fully interacted stacked linear probability model, with the AfD included only from 2013 onward. The post indicator, co-presence controls, respondent characteristics, and event fixed effects are all allowed to vary by focal party. The joint implementation therefore imposes no equality restrictions across parties and is algebraically equivalent to estimating the six party equations separately. Each party equation compares respondents interviewed on the broadcast day with respondents interviewed on the following day. For party p , the main co-presence-adjusted equation is

$$Y_{ig}^p = \beta_p Post_{ig} + \sum_{q \neq p} \delta_{pq} (Post_{ig} \times CoPresence_{gq}) + X_i' \gamma_p + \alpha_g + \varepsilon_{ig}^p. \quad (1)$$

Here, g indexes a party-appearance event window and Y_{ig}^p is the support outcome for party p for respondent i in event window g , measured in percentage points. $Post_{ig}$

equals one for respondents interviewed on the day after the broadcast and zero for respondents interviewed on the broadcast day. $CoPresence_{gq}$ indicates that another major party q appeared in the same episode, X_i contains respondent controls, and α_g denotes event-window fixed effects. The coefficient β_p therefore measures the immediate change in support for party p after its appearance, net of the same-episode post effects associated with other major parties appearing in the broadcast. The stacked formulation also recovers the cross-party covariance matrix. I use this matrix to estimate the equally weighted average $\bar{\beta} = \frac{1}{6} \sum_{p=1}^6 \beta_p$ and its standard error. This estimand is not the coefficient from a model that constrains all parties to have one common post effect; such a coefficient would implicitly weight parties by their residual treatment variation and sample information.

I cluster standard errors by interview date. The same original survey observation can enter more than one party-appearance event window when several relevant appearances occur around the same dates and, in the stacked model, can also be used for different focal parties. Date clustering keeps all repeated uses of an original survey observation in the same cluster. It also allows for correlated errors among different respondents interviewed on the same day because they share the same contemporaneous political, media, and survey environment. Interview-date fixed effects are not a suitable alternative because they would restrict identification to dates that are simultaneously post for some appearances and pre for others, thereby changing the estimand. As an inference check, clustering by party-appearance event or jointly by interview date and event raises the standard error of the 0.138-point equal-party average from 0.034 to 0.049 and 0.048, respectively, but leaves the average statistically significant ($p = 0.005$ and $p = 0.004$). Appendix Section A.5 provides the fuller justification.

To examine timing beyond the main comparison, I estimate party-specific anchored event-study specifications from two days before to four days after an appearance, with the broadcast day as the reference category, and summarize them using the equal-weighted average across parties.

4.2 Robustness and timing checks

I complement the main specification with three alternative dynamic estimators: a repeated-cross-section distributed-lag model, a pseudo-panel fixed-effects autoregressive distributed-lag (FE-ARDL) model, and local projections. These estimators use different units of observation and different assumptions about persistence, so I use them to assess whether the sign and short-run timing of the response are robust to alternative dynamic specifications rather than as interchangeable estimates of a single parameter. Appendix Section A.6.1 provides the full specifications and estimating equations.

The key timing assumption is that the talk-show day is a valid pre-treatment survey day. I test this directly with a no-anticipation placebo that compares respondents interviewed on the day before the broadcast with respondents interviewed on the broadcast day. If the main broadcast-day to next-day estimates merely reflect pre-existing trends, one should already see systematic movement from the day before the broadcast to the broadcast day. The placebo specification is identical to the main model except that the day before the broadcast is the reference day and the broadcast day is the placebo post day. A null or negative placebo pattern supports the interpretation that the main estimates are not driven by anticipatory changes before the evening broadcast.

4.3 Heterogeneity and mechanisms

Party competence. As a complementary party-evaluation outcome, I examine whether appearances change which party respondents regard as best able to solve Germany’s problems. For each appearing party, the outcome equals one hundred when the respondent names that party and zero otherwise. I estimate the same co-presence-adjusted specification used for support. The item is available only to a questionnaire subsample in later years, which reduces precision relative to vote intention.

Economic expectations. I examine whether talk-show appearances shift respondents’ expectations about Germany’s economic trajectory. The forsa survey asks whether respondents expect the economic situation in Germany to improve, remain unchanged, or worsen. I summarize the three ordered responses in an optimism score that equals +1 for “improve,” 0 for “unchanged,” and −1 for “worsen.” The treatment coefficient on this score is therefore the change in the probability of expecting improvement minus the change in the probability of expecting deterioration; negative estimates indicate a net shift toward pessimism. Using a single score provides a compact summary of the full response distribution, while Appendix Section A.7 reports the separate category-specific estimates. The economic-expectations models use the same event-window comparison as the main party-support analysis and include event-window fixed effects, individual controls, co-presence controls, and interview-date clustered standard errors. I additionally aggregate appearances according to whether the appearing party was in federal government or opposition on the broadcast date and estimate the corresponding status-based effects on economic expectations.

Party size. To assess whether the return to visibility differs with a party’s electoral strength, I measure strictly pre-event support as the respondent-weighted vote-intention share during days $t - 37$ through $t - 8$. This 30-day window leaves a one-week gap before the appearance and therefore does not use contemporaneous or post-appearance support to define party size. I interact the event-study indicator with this continuous measure, centered at 10 percent. I then decompose size into a between-party component—the party’s average pre-event strength across its appearances—and a within-party component—the event-specific deviation from that party average. The between term asks whether parties that are generally smaller obtain larger returns from visibility; the within term asks whether the same party obtains a larger return when it is temporarily weaker. These models retain the respondent controls, event fixed effects, co-presence controls, intervening-appearance controls, and interview-date clustering used in the corresponding event-study specifications.

Heterogeneity. I examine how the immediate support effects differ across respondent characteristics. The main text reports heterogeneity by household income, age, and municipality size, while education and gender are reported as supplementary demographic checks. These analyses describe variation in the estimated effects across groups rather than imposing a common response across the survey population.

Politician novelty, reinforcement, and supplementary checks. Two additional mechanisms are considered. First, I test whether first or early appearances by politicians have especially large effects. If talk shows work partly by introducing voters to less

familiar political elites, first appearances should be especially informative because voters may learn that a party has a new or unexpected type of representative in its ranks. Second, I test whether the effects primarily reflect reinforcement among previous own-party voters. These reinforcement tests compare respondents who previously voted for the appearing party with respondents who previously voted for another party, using pooled interaction specifications. Supplementary analyses further compare party effects across periods of federal government and opposition and report politician-specific estimates, including separate checks for AfD politicians with repeated appearances.

5 Results

5.1 Immediate effects on support and competence

Table 3 reports the primary support specification with co-presence controls. The $t = +1$ estimates compare the broadcast day with the following day in a fully interacted stacked model. The equal-weighted party average is 0.139 percentage points per appearance. As an alternative summary, I also estimate a common event-weighted effect that gives every usable appearance the same weight. Its next-day estimate is 0.081 percentage points ($p = 0.027$), so the immediate positive response is not driven only by assigning equal weight to relatively infrequent parties.

The party-specific estimates show that the equal-party average masks substantial heterogeneity. The FDP (0.259) and SPD (0.171) effects are positive and statistically precise, while the AfD has the largest point estimate (0.301). CDU/CSU, Greens, and the Left have imprecise estimates. The one-day placebo estimates are statistically insignificant for every individual party and in both the equal-weighted and event-weighted averages; Appendix Table A3 reports these diagnostics. The size moderation discussed below comes primarily from differences between generally small and generally large parties: the between-party coefficient is negative and statistically precise, whereas the similarly signed within-party coefficient is imprecise. Thus, the estimates do not show that an established large party necessarily begins to benefit more whenever its own support declines.

The aggregated rows in Table 3 ask whether an appearance benefits the appearing party's broader political bloc. Government, opposition, left-bloc, and right-bloc appearances are all followed by positive point estimates for support of the corresponding bloc, ranging from 0.037 to 0.097 percentage points. Only the government estimate is marginally significant. Because these rows pool parties whose composition and political position change over time, they are best read as descriptive system-level summaries rather than additional clean causal tests; the corresponding bloc placebo estimates are reported in Appendix Table A3.

Figure 4 overlays the anchored support and competence profiles. Their next-day averages are strikingly similar: 0.139 percentage points for support and 0.121 points for perceived problem-solving competence. Support remains positive at $t = +2$. Its two average leads are close to zero, whereas competence has a modest positive $t = -1$ estimate. Appendix Figure A4 reports the party-specific support profiles.

Table 3: Immediate effects on party and political-bloc support

Party or bloc	$t = +1$ effect	Unique respondents	Respondent–event obs.	Usable events
SPD	0.171** (0.065)	1,239,185	1,435,076	1,494
CDU/CSU	0.043 (0.062)	1,488,900	1,762,769	1,835
Greens	-0.051 (0.076)	848,695	928,559	967
FDP	0.259*** (0.062)	605,069	650,971	677
AfD	0.301** (0.142)	123,050	126,948	131
Left	0.105 (0.071)	446,269	473,221	492
Equal-weighted party average	0.139*** (0.034)	1,963,931	5,377,544	5,596
Event-weighted average	0.081** (0.037)	1,963,931	5,377,544	5,596
<i>Aggregated bloc outcomes</i>				
Government bloc	0.097* (0.059)	1,963,931	2,656,118	2,762
Opposition bloc	0.037 (0.069)	1,963,931	2,656,118	2,762
Left bloc	0.069 (0.053)	1,963,931	2,656,118	2,762
Right bloc	0.086 (0.053)	1,963,931	2,656,118	2,762

Notes: Percentage-point estimates with interview-date clustered standard errors in parentheses. All models include individual controls, event fixed effects, and co-presence controls. “Unique respondents” counts each original forsa respondent once within a row; the average rows additionally deduplicate respondents across parties. “Respondent–event obs.” counts all uses of respondents in appearance windows. The equal-weighted party average and its standard error use the joint cross-party covariance matrix. The event-weighted row gives every balanced party-appearance event the same total weight. Bloc outcomes equal support for any party in the corresponding bloc. Government membership varies with the federal cabinet in office; the fixed left bloc comprises SPD, Greens, and the Left, and the fixed right bloc comprises CDU/CSU, FDP, and AfD. Bloc treatments indicate that at least one member party appeared on the date, with multiple same-bloc appearances collapsed to one event; each bloc model controls for same-episode presence of the counterpart bloc. Appendix Table A3 reports the $t = -1$ placebo estimates. The remaining event-weighted estimates at $t = -2$, $t = +2$, and $t = +3$ are -0.006 , -0.025 , and -0.102 , respectively, and are statistically insignificant. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Party size and the return to visibility. Figure 3 relates the estimated next-day effect to the appearing party’s strictly pre-event support. The fitted effect declines from 0.164 percentage points for a party at 3 percent support to 0.132 points at 10 percent, 0.085 points at 20 percent, and approximately zero at 40 percent. The pooled linear moderation coefficient is -0.00466 percentage points per additional percentage point of pre-event support ($p = 0.028$). Thus, the estimates show a clear descriptive gradient: appearances by smaller parties are followed by larger support gains than appearances by larger parties.

The full decomposition in Appendix Table A13 indicates that this gradient is primarily a between-party pattern. The next-day between-party coefficient is -0.00435 ($p = 0.048$), whereas the within-party coefficient has the same sign but is imprecise (-0.00556 , $p = 0.272$). A plausible visibility interpretation is that generally smaller parties receive less routine attention and therefore obtain more marginal reach, salience, or legitimation from a prominent appearance. By contrast, formerly large parties may retain public familiarity and routine media reach even after losing support, limiting the additional return to a single appearance. Because the analysis does not directly measure prior awareness or total media exposure, this mechanism interpretation remains suggestive.

This pattern should not be interpreted as a causally identified effect of party size. The pooled size-moderation coefficients in the two pre-periods are jointly distinguishable from zero ($p = 0.047$), and the within-party component also exhibits pre-period moderation.

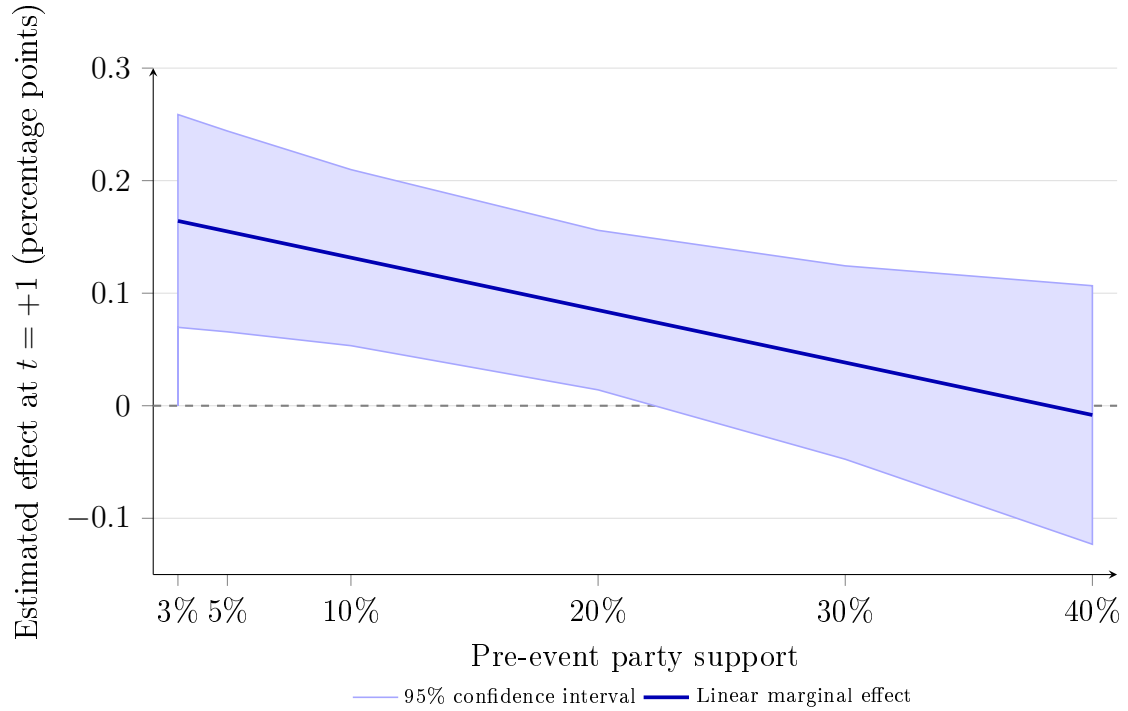


Figure 3: Next-day talk-show effect by pre-event party support

Notes: The figure reports marginal effects from a pooled linear interaction between the next-day indicator and the appearing party’s support. Pre-event support is the respondent-weighted vote-intention share during days $t - 37$ through $t - 8$. Models include respondent controls, event fixed effects, co-presence controls, and interview-date clustered standard errors. Shading shows 95% confidence intervals.

The between-party pre-period coefficients are individually imprecise, but with only six parties this component necessarily captures persistent differences among party types as well as size. I therefore treat the finding as descriptive heterogeneity consistent with a visibility mechanism, not as proof that reducing a party’s support would itself raise the return to an appearance.

Substantive magnitude. A deliberately simple back-of-the-envelope calculation helps put these small percentage-point estimates in context. If the estimated next-day responses were locally linear, additive, and generated by sufficiently separated appearances, five additional appearances at the equal-weighted party estimate would correspond to about 0.69 percentage points more reported support; ten would correspond to about 1.38 points. Applying the same arithmetic to the FDP estimate, four additional appearances would correspond to roughly 1.04 percentage points. This scale is potentially consequential for a small party near the electoral threshold: the FDP received 4.8 percent of the second vote in 2013 and 4.3 percent in 2025, missing the five-percent threshold by 0.2 and 0.7 points, respectively (Bundeswahlleiter, 2013; Bundeswahlleiterin, 2025). This comparison is not a counterfactual claim that additional talk-show appearances would have changed either election result. The regressions estimate short-run changes in survey support, not election-day vote shares, and repeated effects may overlap, decay, or saturate. The calculation instead shows that effects that appear small per appearance are of an electorally meaningful order of magnitude when visibility is repeatedly allocated.

Because viewing is not observed in the forsa data, the reduced-form estimates cannot identify an average treatment effect among viewers. A simple sensitivity scaling nev-

ertheless conveys the order of magnitude. The harmonized forsa analysis file contains respondents aged 18 and older and is not restricted to German citizens. I therefore use Germany’s 69.6 million residents aged 18 and older in 2025 as the adult-population benchmark (Destatis, 2026). The equal-weighted population estimate of 0.139 percentage points then corresponds to a net increase of approximately 96,700 adults reporting support for the appearing party. If two million adults viewed the program, concentrating the entire population response among them would imply an average viewer response of 4.84 percentage points, or about 48 additional supporters per 1,000 viewers. With four million adult viewers, the same aggregate response would instead imply 2.42 points, or about 24 per 1,000. The event-weighted estimate of 0.081 points corresponds to approximately 56,400 additional adult supporters and implies 2.82 points with two million viewers or 1.41 points with four million viewers—about 28 or 14 additional supporters per 1,000 viewers, respectively.

These scenarios do not add new identifying information: multiplying each implied viewer response by its assumed audience reproduces the original population-level estimate by construction. They should therefore be interpreted as implied viewer effects, not as identified viewer-level ATTs or counts of individual switchers. The calculations assume that the full net population response arises among directly exposed adults, that there are no spillovers to non-viewers, and that the reported audience size correctly measures adult exposure to the focal appearance. If published ratings include viewers younger than 18, the relevant adult audience is smaller but unobserved. The calculations also describe a net change in reported support; the repeated cross-sections do not reveal the gross number of individuals moving toward and away from the party.

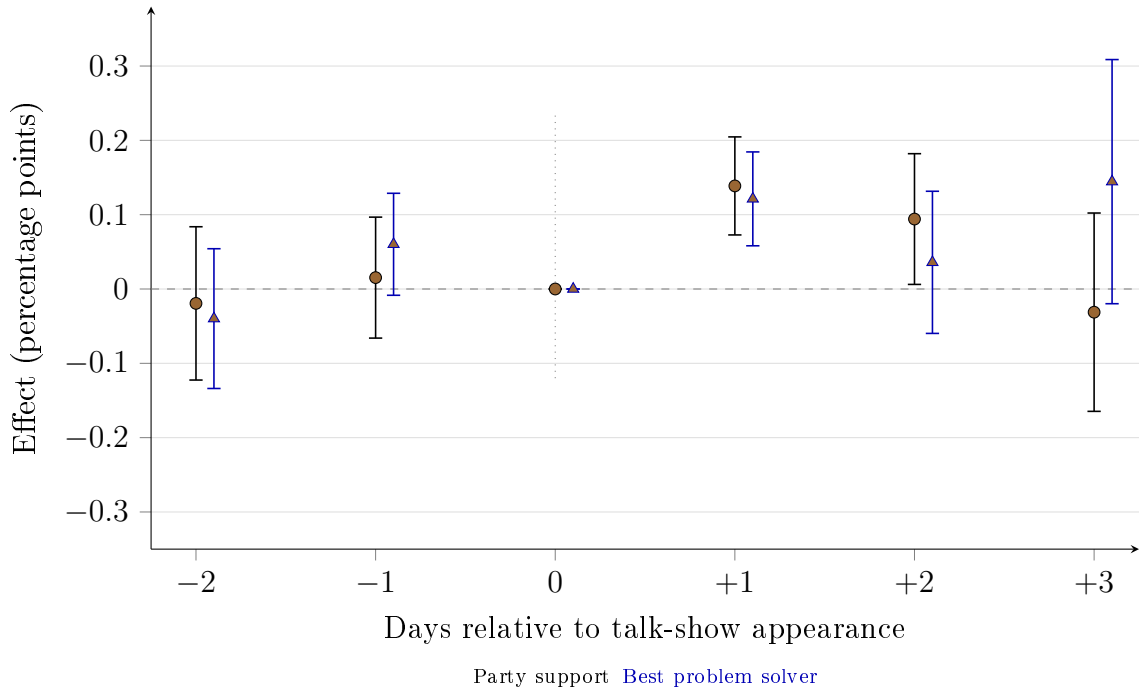


Figure 4: Average event-study estimates for party support and perceived problem-solving competence

Notes: Points are equal-weighted party averages; $t = 0$ is the reference. Models include respondent controls, event fixed effects, co-presence controls, and controls for intervening appearances where applicable. The competence item is available to a smaller questionnaire sample. Whiskers are 95% confidence intervals; competence intervals use a covariance-free approximation.

Table 4 reports the party-specific competence estimates. The AfD (0.336), CDU/CSU (0.297), and the Left (0.104) have positive and statistically precise effects; the remaining estimates are small and imprecise. The equal-weighted average of 0.123 points is close to the 0.138-point support average. The competence sample is nevertheless much smaller because the item was not asked to every respondent, especially in later survey years.

The different party patterns are substantively plausible because perceived competence and vote intention need not move together. The Left may convince some respondents that it diagnoses or can solve problems without becoming their vote choice, for example because its prospects of entering government are limited. For the FDP, visibility as a small party may increase electoral support even when respondents do not name it the single best problem solver, perhaps because they value it tactically as a coalition partner or corrective. The AfD and the Left also foreground decline and crisis and present themselves as remedies to those crises. Their negative effects on economic expectations and their competence gains are consistent with that strategy affecting problem perceptions; only for the AfD does it translate into a comparably clear support gain.

The competence timing evidence is less clean than the support average: its $t = -1$ estimate is 0.060 points and marginally significant, driven by an AfD lead of 0.451 points. No other party has a statistically precise competence lead. I therefore treat this single-party pre-pattern as a qualification and the competence results as complementary evidence rather than an independent causal confirmation.

Table 4: Effects on perceived problem-solving competence

Party	Effect	Unique respondents	Respondent–event obs.	Usable events
SPD	0.054	857,244	982,594	1,494
CDU/CSU	0.297***	1,030,532	1,209,940	1,835
Greens	-0.031	580,133	628,226	967
FDP	-0.025	422,627	454,461	677
AfD	0.336***	64,716	66,625	131
Left	0.104**	317,258	337,585	492
Equal-weighted average	0.123	1,381,416	3,679,431	5,596

Notes: Percentage-point effects from the support-model specification. The outcome is one hundred when the appearing party is named as best able to solve Germany’s problems. The item is available to a smaller questionnaire sample. Unique respondents are deduplicated within party rows and across parties in the average row; respondent–event observations count repeated uses across appearance windows. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

5.2 Robustness and timing checks

Figure 5 reports the three alternative dynamic estimators from $t = -2$ through $t = +3$. All point in the same positive direction at $t = +1$: the distributed-lag and pseudo-panel FE-ARDL estimates are statistically precise, while the local-projection estimate is marginally significant. The first two models remain positive at $t = +2$, and the distributed-lag estimate remains positive at $t = +3$, consistent with a response concentrated shortly after an appearance.

The support pre-period evidence is not perfectly flat, but the departures are isolated. The anchored average leads are close to zero, with CDU/CSU providing the only statistically precise party-specific $t = -2$ lead. In the alternatives, the distributed-lag and FE-ARDL averages have insignificant leads, although isolated AfD and SPD party leads point in opposite directions; the local-projection average is negative at $t = -2$, driven in part by CDU/CSU. Because these estimates do not recur with a common party, sign, or model, they caution against an unqualified causal reading without forming a systematic pre-trend. Appendix Section A.6.1 reports the full specifications and diagnostics.

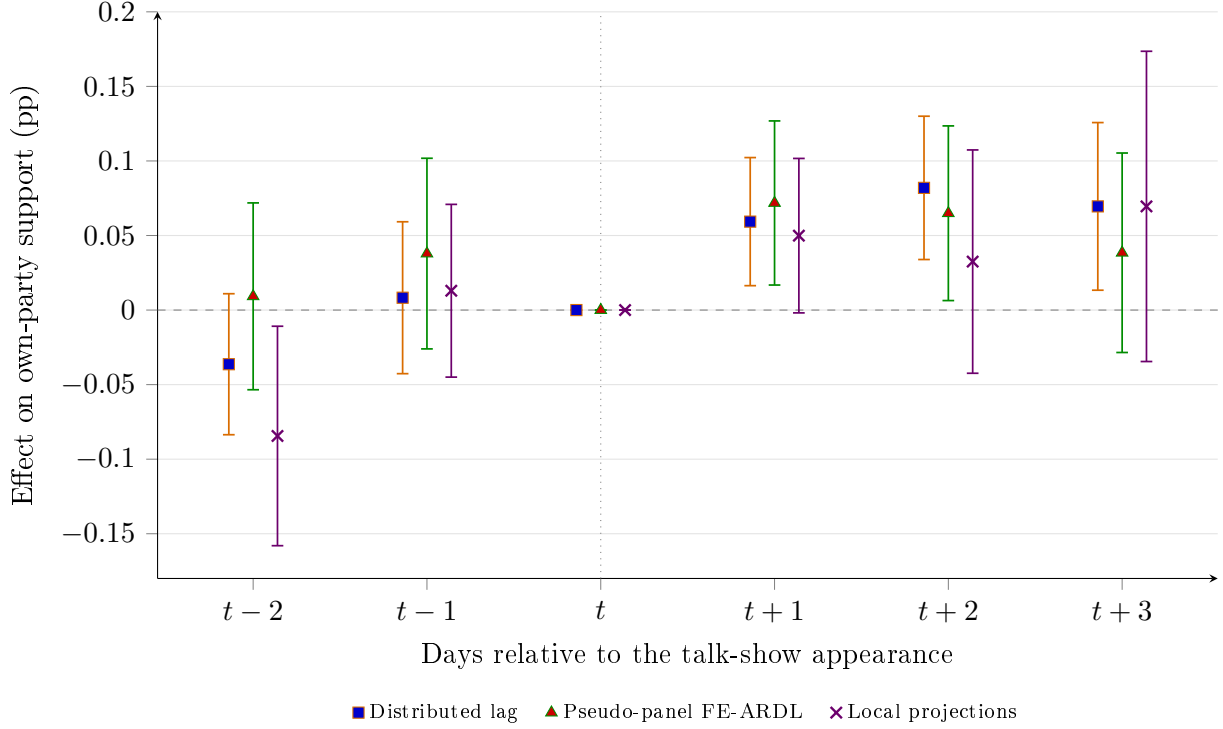


Figure 5: Dynamic robustness across alternative estimators

Notes: Points are equal-weighted party averages; $t = 0$ is the reference. All models include co-presence controls. Whiskers are 95% confidence intervals. Distributed-lag and FE-ARDL average intervals use a covariance-free approximation; local-projection intervals use the pooled covariance matrix.

5.3 Economic expectations

I then examine whether talk-show appearances shift respondents' expectations about Germany's economic trajectory. Figure 6 reports the optimism score defined above, with improvement coded as +1, unchanged as 0, and deterioration as -1. The coefficient is equivalently the change in the probability of expecting improvement minus the change in the probability of expecting deterioration, so negative values indicate a net shift toward economic pessimism. In the preferred specification, AfD appearances reduce the score by 3.51 percentage points and Left appearances by 1.06 points. CDU/CSU appearances increase it by 0.82 points and FDP appearances by 0.66 points. The separate category-specific coefficients are reported in the appendix.

At the date level, appearances by a currently governing party increase the optimism score by 0.425 percentage points (***, 95% CI [0.150, 0.700]), whereas the opposition estimate is small and statistically insignificant at 0.068 points (95% CI [-0.247, 0.383]). The pessimistic AfD and Left estimates therefore do not reflect an opposition effect per se; they are party-specific departures from the aggregate opposition pattern. The full estimates are reported in Appendix A.7.

As a descriptive attenuation check, I add the optimism score to the support regression on the common sample with valid expectations. The AfD estimate falls from 0.144 to 0.069 points and the Left estimate from 0.134 to 0.125 points. This is directionally consistent with partial attenuation, especially for the AfD, but it does not identify mediation because expectations are post-treatment. Appendix Table A6 reports all six parties. More generally, the substantive patterns for party support, problem-solving competence, and economic expectations hold when standard errors are clustered by party-appearance

event or two ways by interview date and event. The central equal-party averages remain statistically distinguishable from zero at conventional levels under both alternatives; Appendix Table A2 reports the full comparison.

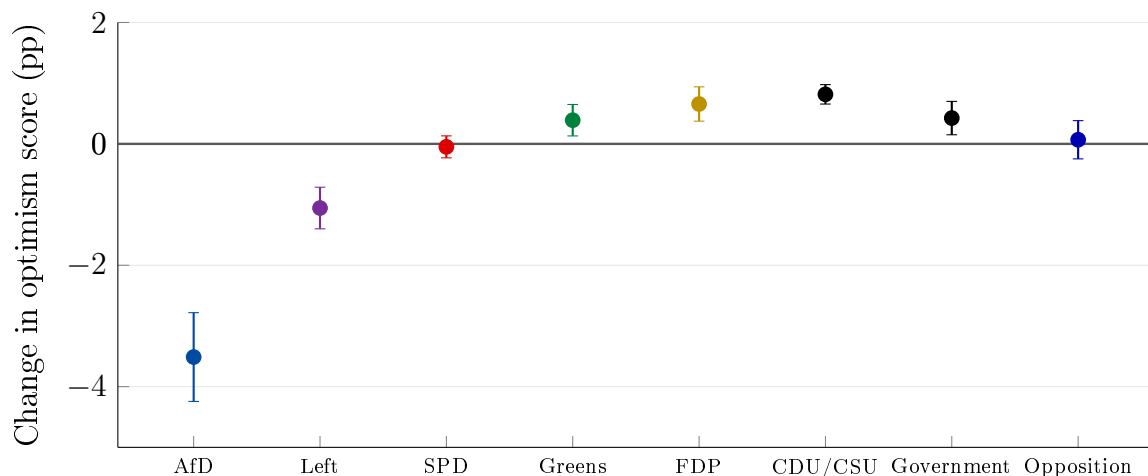


Figure 6: Talk-show appearances and economic expectations. The optimism score ranges from -1 (worsen) to $+1$ (improve). Points report co-presence-adjusted estimates; whiskers are approximate 95% confidence intervals. Models include respondent controls and event fixed effects, with standard errors clustered by interview date.

5.4 Economic pessimism and support for populist parties

The expectation results show that AfD and Left appearances shift economic evaluations in a pessimistic direction. I next ask how this evaluative shift maps onto the broader party system. Figure 7 summarizes the conditional association between economic expectations and support for all six parties in a net-optimism score, defined as the support contrast between expecting improvement and expecting deterioration. The five established parties use all available survey years (1998–2025); AfD uses 2013–2025, when its vote-intention measure is available. The updated score is strongly negative for the AfD (-3.35 percentage points) and the Left (-1.44), near zero for the FDP (-0.07), and positive for the Greens (0.69), CDU/CSU (5.51), and SPD (6.40). It summarizes the full expectation gradient in a single coefficient while retaining the covariance between the two underlying contrasts. The separate Improve and Worsen coefficients are reported in Appendix Table A7.

The party-system contrast strengthens the grievance-alignment interpretation. AfD and Left appearances move expectations toward the category associated with greater support for these parties and lower support for most competitors. This does not mean that pessimism itself has been randomly assigned. Expectations and vote intentions are elicited in the same interview, so their relationship is contemporaneous and does not identify a causal effect of pessimism on party choice. The combination of a treatment effect on expectations and a sharply structured expectation–support association is therefore suggestive mechanism evidence rather than formal mediation. Appendix Table A7 reports the regression estimates.

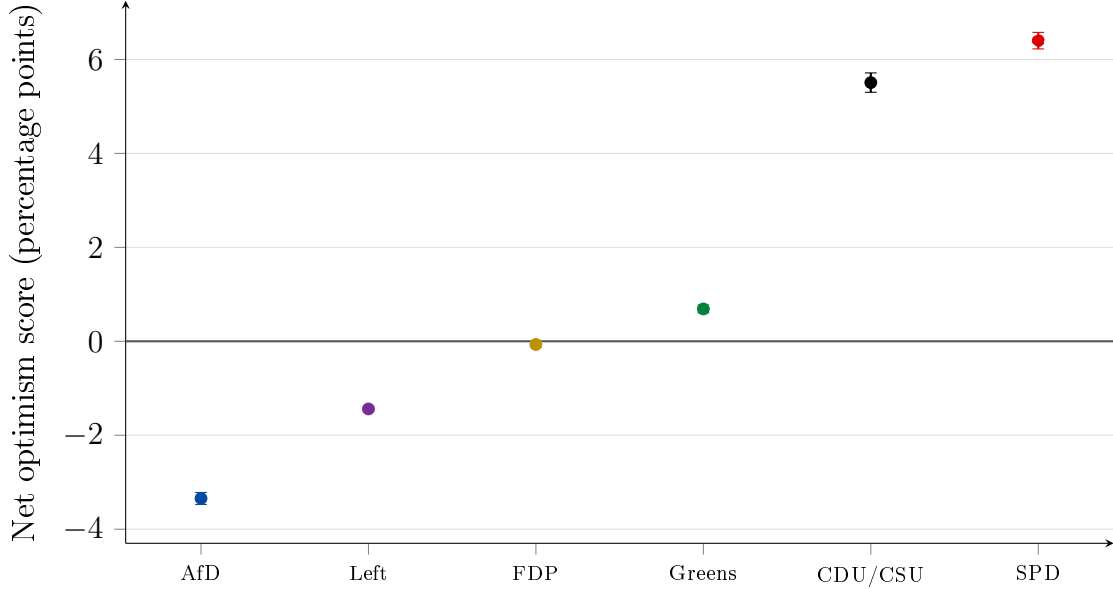


Figure 7: Economic expectations and party support across six parties. *Notes:* The net-optimism score equals the difference in party support between respondents expecting economic improvement and respondents expecting deterioration. Its 95% confidence interval is calculated from the joint covariance of the two underlying contrasts. Parties are ordered from the most negative to the most positive score. Models include interview-date fixed effects and controls for household income, sex, education, age, previous vote, state, and municipality size. Standard errors are clustered by interview date. The five established parties use 1998–2025; AfD uses 2013–2025. Whiskers show 95% confidence intervals.

5.5 Heterogeneity across respondent groups

Heterogeneity provides supporting context for this interpretation rather than a separate mediation test. I consider income, age, municipality size, education, and gender together, placing most weight on the first three because they yield the clearest substantive patterns.

Figure 8 shows the income-specific support effects for the two focal parties in the primary co-presence-adjusted specification. Both parties obtain their clearest gains among respondents with household income below 1,500 euros: the AfD estimate is 1.01 points and the corresponding Left estimate is 0.43 points. The parties diverge at the top of the distribution. AfD appearances also increase support among respondents above 4,000 euros, producing a U-shaped profile, whereas the Left estimate is negative in that group.

This pattern is compatible with economic vulnerability but does not reduce to it. Lower-income respondents are on average substantially more pessimistic about the economy, making their strong support response consistent with heightened receptiveness to messages about decline, insecurity, and redistribution. The AfD’s high-income gain indicates that pessimistic narratives can also resonate through status concerns, immigration, taxation, or anti-establishment appeals among respondents who are not economically deprived. Moreover, the income-specific expectation shifts do not reproduce the support profiles closely, especially for the Left. Income therefore identifies politically responsive constituencies but does not establish mediation. The full income tables are reported in Appendix Sections A.8 and A.10.2.

Age provides a second pattern consistent with vulnerability over the life cycle. AfD

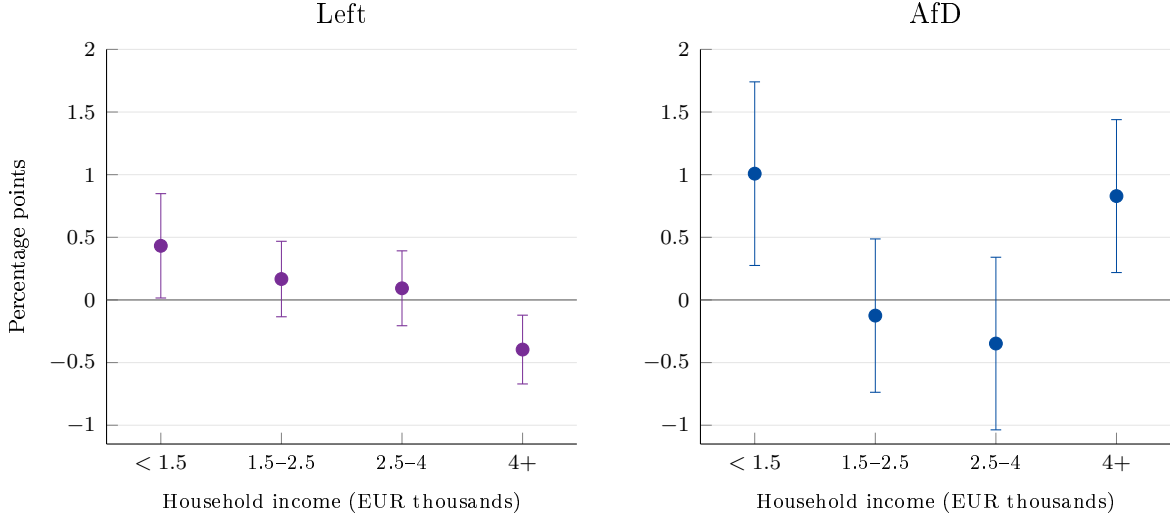


Figure 8: Income heterogeneity for the two focal parties. Points report pooled interaction specifications with co-presence controls. Whiskers show 95% confidence intervals.

effects are most pronounced among respondents aged 45–59. For this group, employment insecurity, occupational status loss, and fears of downward mobility may be especially salient because adverse economic developments can threaten established careers while leaving less time for adjustment before retirement. Left effects follow a different profile: they are most visible among the youngest and oldest respondents. This is consistent with the party’s appeal to younger voters concerned about insecure labor-market entry and housing costs, and to older voters attentive to pensions, welfare provision, and social protection. The age results therefore fit distinct forms of economic vulnerability rather than a single monotonic gradient.

The geographic split points in a similar direction. AfD effects are strongest in medium-sized municipalities outside the largest urban centers, where concerns about local decline, service provision, demographic change, migration, and relative status may be particularly salient. Left effects are concentrated in large cities, consistent with the party’s established urban constituencies and the prominence of rent, inequality, precarious employment, and redistribution in metropolitan politics. Municipality size is an imperfect proxy for these local conditions, but the contrast aligns with the different grievance narratives emphasized by the two parties.

Education and gender reveal less coherent gradients and are therefore treated as supplementary checks. AfD effects are positive among both lower-education and tertiary-education respondents rather than following a simple educational gradient, while the Left estimates are more visible among respondents with lower/basic schooling. Gender differences are imprecise for both focal parties and do not provide a stable organizing pattern. The complete age, municipality-size, education, and gender estimates are reported in Appendix Tables A15, A16, A17, and A18.

5.6 Who gains from whom?

The repeated cross-sections provide two complementary, but non-equivalent, ways to characterize where the estimated gains originate. First, I interact an appearance with respondents’ reported vote in the previous federal election. This identifies which previously

defined electoral groups are especially responsive, although it cannot show an individual transition between the talk-show day and the following day. Second, I estimate how current support for other parties changes from the talk-show day to the next day. This second exercise reveals which aggregate support categories rise or fall alongside the appearing party, but it likewise does not track the same individuals over time. I therefore treat both decompositions as evidence on the composition of the response rather than as literal voter-flow estimates.

The previous-vote results do not reveal a general tendency for parties to draw disproportionately from their own ideological side. For the SPD, the estimated effect among previous left-bloc voters is 0.464 percentage points, compared with -0.004 among previous right-bloc voters; the 0.468-point difference is statistically significant ($p = 0.002$). Once former SPD voters are excluded, however, the same-side advantage disappears. By contrast, CDU/CSU and FDP appearances generate significantly larger responses among voters of other parties on the right: after excluding previous own-party voters, the same-side-minus-opposite-side differences are 0.728 points for CDU/CSU and 0.325 points for the FDP (both $p = 0.003$). Both survive a Benjamini–Hochberg adjustment across the six party-specific contrasts. The Greens, the AfD, and the Left show no statistically distinguishable same-side advantage.

The AfD instead draws its clearest response from respondents who did not vote in the previous federal election. Their AfD-support response is 2.40 percentage points ($p < 0.001$), whereas the average effects among previous left- and right-bloc voters are statistically indistinguishable. The current-support comparison provides no evidence that the AfD gain comes disproportionately at the expense of either ideological bloc: support for other right parties changes by 0.074 points and support for left parties by 0.246 points, with a statistically insignificant difference. Figure 9 summarizes the two descriptive decompositions. In the left panel, negative current-support coefficients are proportionally allocated to the AfD’s own-party gain; the right panel reports only positive contributions from previous-vote groups. The graphical flows are accounting devices and should not be interpreted as observed individual movements.

For the Left, the two perspectives point to a different pattern. Previous-vote responses do not differ significantly between the left and right blocs. In the current-support comparison, however, support for the SPD and Greens falls by 0.316 points after a Left appearance ($p = 0.037$), while support for parties on the right rises by an imprecisely estimated 0.225 points. The direct contrast between these changes is 0.541 points ($p = 0.029$), indicating that the contemporaneous redistribution accompanying a Left appearance is concentrated within the left bloc. Figure 10 illustrates this pattern. For the remaining parties, the current-support bloc contrasts are statistically insignificant: the SPD and FDP point estimates suggest declines among ideologically adjacent parties, whereas CDU/CSU and Green appearances produce almost no differential movement across blocs. Taken together, the results support party-specific accounts—reactivation for the SPD, within-right-bloc persuasion for CDU/CSU and the FDP, prior-non-voter mobilization for the AfD, and contemporaneous within-left-bloc redistribution for the Left—rather than a general law of ideological within-bloc transfer.

(a) Current-support allocation

(b) Previous-vote contributions

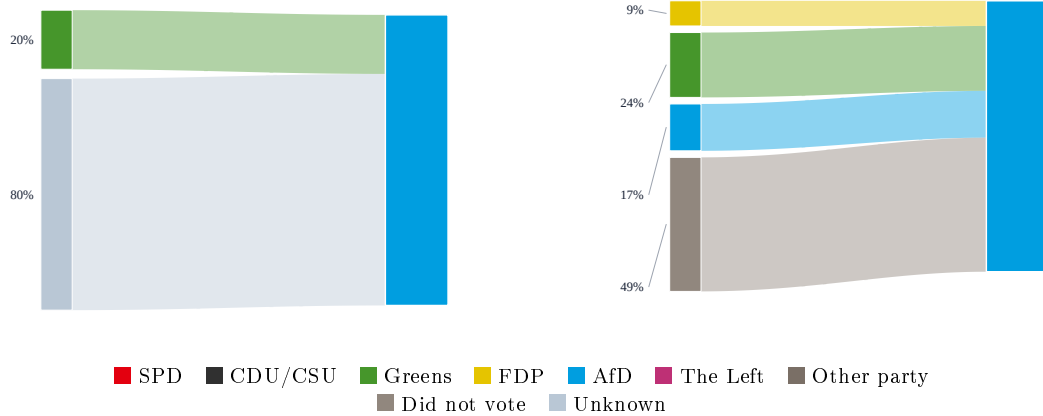


Figure 9: Estimated sources of the AfD support response

Notes: Numbers on the left of each panel report absolute percentage shares and sum to 100 percent apart from rounding. Panel (a) proportionally allocates negative current-support coefficients to the appearing party's estimated own-party gain. Panel (b) decomposes the total of positive composition-weighted contributions from previous-vote groups; negative contributions are omitted. The light-gray category is labeled "Unknown." Both panels summarize aggregate repeated-cross-section estimates at $t + 1$ relative to the talk-show day and do not represent observed individual transitions. If the own-party point estimate is non-positive, a gain-source allocation is undefined and panel (a) reports this instead of imposing an artificial inflow.

(a) Current-support allocation

(b) Previous-vote contributions

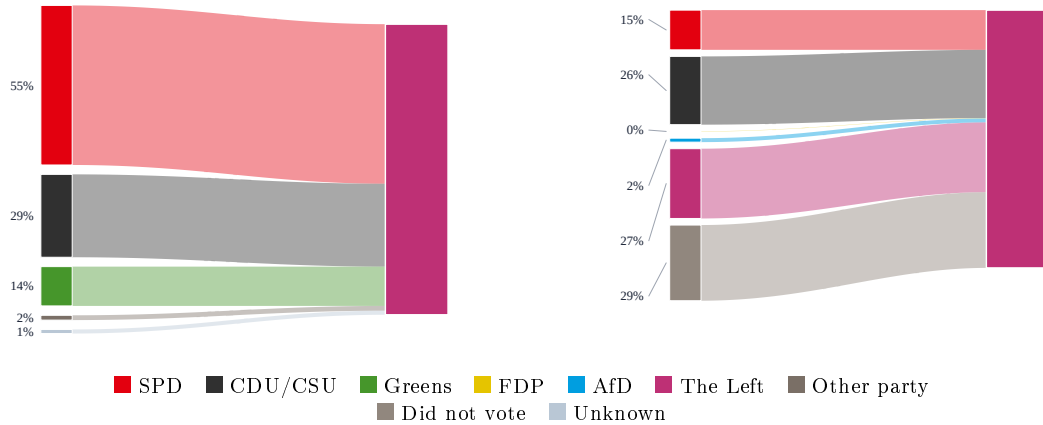


Figure 10: Estimated sources of the Left support response

Notes: Numbers on the left of each panel report absolute percentage shares and sum to 100 percent apart from rounding. Panel (a) proportionally allocates negative current-support coefficients to the appearing party's estimated own-party gain. Panel (b) decomposes the total of positive composition-weighted contributions from previous-vote groups; negative contributions are omitted. The light-gray category is labeled "Unknown." Both panels summarize aggregate repeated-cross-section estimates at $t + 1$ relative to the talk-show day and do not represent observed individual transitions. If the own-party point estimate is non-positive, a gain-source allocation is undefined and panel (a) reports this instead of imposing an artificial inflow. The accompanying formal current-support test shows that the aggregate decline is concentrated among the other parties of the left bloc.

5.7 Additional mechanisms

Finally, I examine whether the main effects can be explained by two additional mechanisms: politician novelty and reinforcement among previous own-party voters. The politician-novelty tests ask whether first or early appearances by a politician are especially consequential. Appendix Table A19 reports interaction terms between the post indicator and different measures of prior talk-show experience. The estimates do not reveal a uniform novelty premium across parties. I therefore treat politician novelty as a party-specific moderator rather than as a general explanation for the main results.

The reinforcement tests ask whether talk-show appearances mainly mobilize respondents who already supported the appearing party in the previous federal election. Appendix Table A20 reports formal interaction tests comparing previous own-party voters with respondents who previously voted for another party. The reinforcement estimates do not reveal a pattern that generalizes across parties. A more disaggregated AfD model nevertheless identifies respondents who did not vote in the previous federal election as an especially responsive group: their estimated increase in AfD support after an AfD appearance is 2.36 percentage points ($p < 0.001$). Targeted pairwise tests indicate that this response exceeds that of most other previous-vote groups, although it is not statistically distinguishable from the estimates for former AfD and FDP voters. This makes activation or persuasion of prior non-voters a substantively important AfD-specific finding and complements the voter-origin decomposition in Section 5.6. Overall, the additional checks point more toward party-specific persuasion and activation than toward a simple novelty or reinforcement mechanism. Additional descriptive checks on government/opposition status and politician-specific effects, including AfD politicians with repeated appearances, are reported in the appendix.

6 Discussion: persistence and cumulative effects

The research design identifies changes immediately around a talk-show appearance more clearly than it identifies the duration of those changes. The preferred event study finds a positive average support response on the next day and a smaller positive response two days after the appearance; by the third day, the average estimate is close to zero and imprecise. This pattern establishes that a response is detectable for approximately one to two days. It does not establish that every affected individual has returned to an earlier opinion by the third day. As the horizon expands, respondents encounter additional news, party communication, conversations, campaign material, and further talk-show appearances. These intervening signals make the later survey contrast progressively less informative about the persistence of the original appearance.

One interpretation is a *default-state model*. Citizens have a relatively stable partisan predisposition or default choice to which they ordinarily return. A persuasive talk-show appearance can temporarily make another party more salient, credible, or attractive, leading some respondents to name that party as the best problem solver or even as the party they would currently vote for. Once the appearance recedes from attention, these respondents revert toward their prior partisan state. Under this interpretation, talk shows mainly create short-lived opinion pulses. They can nevertheless matter when appearances are repeated, occur close to an election, or affect small parties near an electoral threshold, but an isolated appearance need not permanently convert voters.

A second interpretation is a *state-transition model*. Citizens update their current

political state when they receive persuasive new information and remain in that state until a subsequent signal moves them again. The next signal could be another talk show, a party manifesto, a campaign encounter, a news event, a political scandal, or a personal economic experience. On this account, an appearance can have a persistent effect for the people it persuades even if the aggregate event-study coefficient later attenuates. Some exposed respondents may remain in the new state, while others receive additional and potentially countervailing information. Because those later signals are unevenly distributed, the average contrast can fade without implying that the original individual-level updates have all disappeared. Talk-show access would then affect the evolving stock of party support, not merely a sequence of transitory daily responses.

The repeated-cross-sectional data cannot discriminate cleanly between these two accounts. Different respondents are interviewed at each horizon, and the probability of intervening political information rises rapidly with time. Restricting the analysis to unusually quiet windows would reduce contamination but would also select a non-representative subset of appearances and still would not reveal whether the same individuals retained their updated views. The most defensible conclusion is therefore deliberately limited: talk-show appearances produce measurable opinion changes over the following one to two days, while the design neither demonstrates nor rules out longer-lived individual effects. A direct test of persistence would require re-interviewing the same respondents, measuring their subsequent media and political exposures, or experimentally varying exposure and following participants over time.

6.1 Dynamic proportional-visibility counterfactual

To make the substantive implications of this uncertainty transparent, I use a dynamic counterfactual that links party support to subsequent talk-show access. The exercise does not estimate a new long-run causal effect. Instead, it asks how the observed political path would have differed if the available talk-show slots had been allocated in proportion to recent party support, under explicit assumptions about how long the estimated short-run response persists.

The simulation holds fixed every observed program date and the number of party slots on that date. For a program on day t , counterfactual invitation probabilities are proportional to respondent-weighted party support measured from $t - 21$ through $t - 8$. This provides a 14-day polling window and allows for a seven-day editorial planning lag. Parties are sampled without replacement. The resulting difference between counterfactual and observed appearances changes support, and simulated support then enters the polling window used to allocate later appearances. Thus, the allocation and support processes feed back into one another. The baseline applies the equal-weighted event-study estimates to every party: 0.139 percentage points at $t + 1$ and 0.094 points at $t + 2$.

Figure 11 displays the upstream allocation stage under the empirically anchored specification in which the direct effect ends after $t + 2$. Proportional allocation would not simply have distributed appearances equally. Rather, it would have tracked the parties' evolving support with the one-week planning lag. Over the full sample, the median counterfactual reallocates approximately 175 party-date appearances toward the Greens, 184 toward the AfD, and 131 toward CDU/CSU, while assigning approximately 310 fewer to the FDP, 105 fewer to the SPD, and 77 fewer to the Left. The annual paths show that both the direction and magnitude of these reallocations vary over time.

I next vary only the duration of the direct support response. The strict scenario

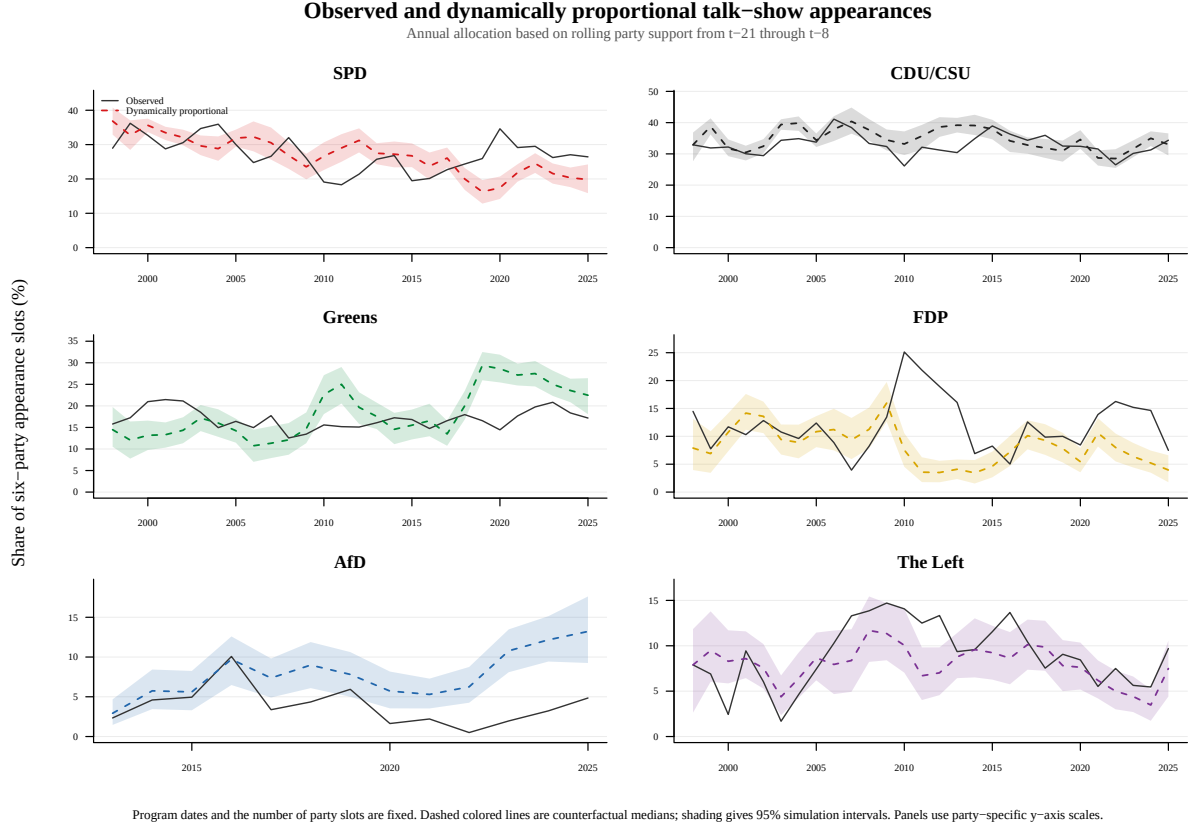


Figure 11: Observed and dynamically proportional talk-show appearances

Notes: The solid black lines show each party's observed annual share of the six-party appearance slots. Dashed colored lines show the median share under dynamic proportional allocation, and shaded areas show 95% simulation intervals from 2,000 Monte Carlo draws. Invitation weights use respondent-weighted support from $t - 21$ through $t - 8$. Program dates and the total number of party slots are fixed. The displayed allocation uses the common equal-weighted event-study effects at $t + 1$ and $t + 2$, with no direct persistence thereafter. Panels use party-specific vertical scales.

sets the direct effect to zero after $t + 2$. The finite-persistence scenarios apply geometric decay corresponding to half-lives of seven, 100, and 365 days. Importantly, even the strict scenario remains dynamic: its short-run support changes can alter later invitation probabilities and thereby generate new appearances and new short-run effects.

Figure 12 shows how strongly the resulting support paths depend on this persistence assumption. With effects confined to $t+1$ and $t+2$, the median equal-party mean absolute relative displacement from observed support is only 0.087%. It rises to 0.348% with a seven-day half-life. A 100-day half-life produces a displacement of 4.653%; at the party level, median changes then range from -0.483 percentage points for the FDP to $+0.653$ points for the AfD. At a 365-day half-life, the median displacement reaches 17.37%. The continuous calibration reaches an average displacement of approximately 5% at a half-life of about 115 days. Politically consequential cumulative changes therefore require the direct response to decay over months rather than days.

The comparison between the empirically anchored short horizon and the finite-decay scenarios shows that endogenous invitation feedback alone generates little movement when the direct response is short-lived, whereas effects become politically meaningful only after imposing persistence far beyond the observed event-study window.

The party-specific event-study coefficients produce the same qualitative sensitivity to

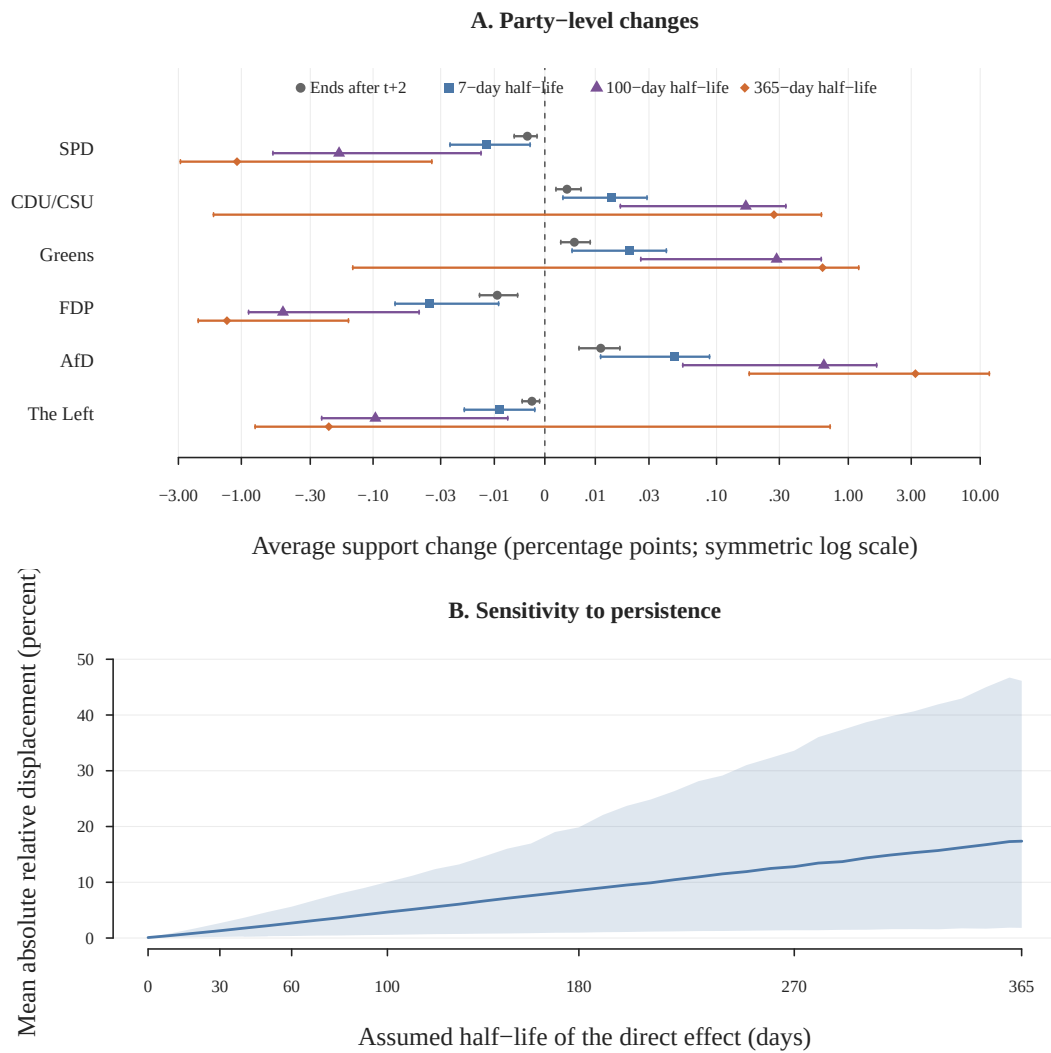


Figure 12: Dynamic visibility counterfactuals under alternative persistence assumptions

Notes: Panel A reports party-level simulation medians for half-lives of zero, seven, 100, and 365 days based on the common equal-weighted event-study coefficients; horizontal whiskers are 95% simulation intervals from 2,000 Monte Carlo draws. Its symmetric log-like horizontal axis is linear very near zero and logarithmic away from zero, while tick labels remain in the original percentage-point units. Panel B reports the equal-party mean absolute relative displacement across direct-effect half-lives from 0 to 365 days, evaluated every 10 days and additionally at 7 and 365 days. The solid line gives the simulation median and the shaded area the 95% simulation interval, based on 2,000 draws at every grid point. All specifications retain endogenous feedback into subsequent invitations.

persistence but substantially larger and less precise movements for several parties; the corresponding results are reported in Appendix Figure A5. For example, the 100-day scenario produces a median equal-party mean absolute relative displacement of 15.09% when the party-specific coefficients are used, compared with 4.63% under the common effect. I therefore treat the common-effect simulation as the main specification and the party-specific version as a robustness exercise. The intervals are simulation intervals that combine coefficient uncertainty, polling uncertainty, and the invitation lottery; they are not conventional confidence intervals for an independently identified long-run causal parameter. The exercise also holds the remaining political history fixed and does not model campaign adaptation, strategic broadcaster responses, turnout, coalition expectations, or spillovers through other media.

7 Conclusion

This paper combines a new long-run dataset of German political talk-show appearances with daily forsa survey data to study immediate changes in public opinion after party visibility. The analysis uses a narrow event-window design that compares respondents interviewed on the broadcast day with respondents interviewed on the following day and adjusts for same-episode co-presence of other major parties.

The first result is descriptive but central: political talk shows are not passive mirrors of party-system strength. Invitations are not distributed proportionally to survey support. The AfD is underrepresented relative to its vote-intention share in most years after 2013, especially in the most recent period. However, this underrepresentation is not unique; over the same period, the Greens are on average even more underrepresented, and CDU/CSU is persistently underrepresented over the whole sample. Talk-show access is therefore best understood as an allocated political resource shaped by editorial gatekeeping rather than as a direct reflection of electoral strength.

The second result is that this allocated visibility matters. Across parties, talk-show appearances are followed by small but measurable increases in support for the appearing party. The equal-weighted support effect is roughly 0.14 percentage points, and the corresponding competence effect is a similar 0.12 points. Mechanical scaling shows that repeated effects of this magnitude could be electorally meaningful, especially for smaller parties, but the design does not establish that effects accumulate linearly or persist until election day. The dynamic counterfactual sharpens this qualification: endogenous invitation feedback produces little movement when the direct response is restricted to the observed two-day horizon, while an average 5% displacement requires a direct-effect half-life of approximately 115 days. Exploratory size moderation likewise shows larger estimated returns for parties that are generally small; the corresponding within-party estimate is imprecise, suggesting that the pattern reflects persistent differences between smaller and larger parties rather than large parties becoming more responsive whenever their support falls. This evidence is consistent with visibility having greater marginal value for parties that receive less routine attention, but pre-period moderation prevents a causal size interpretation. The AfD has the largest support point estimate, while the FDP result is the most statistically precise. All three alternative dynamic estimators return a positive next-day support estimate. Average anchored leads are close to zero, although isolated party- and model-specific pre-period estimates make a qualified timing interpretation more appropriate than a claim of uniformly flat pre-trends.

The third result connects visibility to economic perceptions. AfD and Left appearances shift expectations in a pessimistic direction, while respondents expecting deterioration are substantially more likely to support either party. The insignificant aggregate opposition estimate shows that this is not simply an opposition phenomenon. Adding expectations to the support model reduces the AfD and Left point estimates on a common sample, but this post-treatment adjustment is descriptive and does not identify mediation. Heterogeneity provides supporting context: both parties gain most clearly among low-income respondents, while age and municipality-size patterns are compatible with distinct forms of economic, social, and status vulnerability.

The competence results further suggest that crisis-centered communication can improve evaluations without mechanically translating into votes. AfD and Left appearances increase perceived problem-solving competence, consistent with parties emphasizing decline and presenting themselves as remedies, but only the AfD shows a comparably clear support gain. Tactical considerations may help explain why competence and vote intention differ for the Left and the FDP. Because the competence pre-period pattern is concentrated in the AfD, these estimates remain complementary rather than independent causal confirmation.

Supplementary age, municipality-size, education, and gender results are reported in the appendix. Additional mechanism checks provide little evidence that first appearances or reinforcement among previous voters explain the main results in a uniform way.

The analysis shows that mainstream platform access is both selectively allocated and politically consequential. The results therefore speak to debates about media gatekeeping, political normalization, and the electoral consequences of platforming: who receives visibility matters, but the political effects of visibility depend on the narratives parties attach to that visibility and on which groups are most receptive to them.

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A Appendix

This appendix collects supplementary material that is directly tied to the final main specifications. I organize the appendix around party-system background, data construction, timing checks, additional economic-expectation summaries, party-size and respondent-level heterogeneity, mechanism checks, voter-origin decompositions, government/opposition status, bloc-level checks, year-by-year AfD diagnostics, and AfD-specific supplementary checks. I retain the overlap-sample politician-specific figure as descriptive evidence on whether the aggregate effects are driven by a small number of recurring political actors. I omit older or redundant tables that are not used in the current argument, including pending placeholder tables, older cross-party matrices, seven-category municipality-size outputs, federal-state AfD splits, election-proximity bins, full previous-vote longtables, and isolated-appearance politician estimates that do not use the preferred overlap design. The retained tables and figures are intended to support the main empirical claims without turning the appendix into a full archive of intermediate analyses.

A.1 Parties in the analysis

The empirical analysis uses six party groupings that span the principal alternatives in German federal politics during the sample period. The following brief profiles summarize their broad ideological positions and policy emphases (Bundeswahlleiterin, 2025; Bundeszentrale für politische Bildung, 2026).

CDU/CSU. The Christian Democratic Union and the Bavaria-based Christian Social Union form a joint parliamentary group and constitute Germany’s main conservative center-right bloc. They combine Christian-democratic, pro-business, security-oriented, and welfare-compatible positions.

SPD. The Social Democratic Party is Germany’s main center-left party. Its core emphases include labor-market policy, welfare-state protection, pensions, redistribution, and social justice.

The Greens. Alliance 90/The Greens combines ecological policy with progressive, pro-European, socially liberal, and civil-libertarian positions.

FDP. The Free Democratic Party is a liberal and market-oriented party emphasizing entrepreneurship, tax restraint, digitalization, civil liberties, and limited state intervention.

Die Linke. Die Linke (The Left) is positioned to the left of the SPD and the Greens. It emphasizes redistribution, social protection, affordable housing, welfare-state expansion, and anti-capitalist critique.

AfD. The Alternative for Germany combines nationalism, opposition to immigration, Euroscepticism, cultural conservatism, and law-and-order appeals. The paper treats it as a populist far-right party.

A.2 Federal government participation during the sample period

Table A1: Participation in federal government, 1998–2025

Party	Periods in federal government during the sample
CDU/CSU	2005–2021; 2025–
SPD	1998–2009; 2013–
Greens	1998–2005; 2021–2025
FDP	2009–2013; 2021–2024
AfD	Never
The Left	Never

Notes: The table records participation as a coalition party in the federal government during the paper’s 1998–2025 sample. The FDP left the SPD–Green–FDP coalition in November 2024. The CDU/CSU–SPD government took office in May 2025. Sources: Deutscher Bundestag (2026) and Bundesregierung (2025).

A.3 TDOG construction and validation

This section provides additional detail on how TDOG was constructed and validated; Figure A1 summarizes the same process schematically. The material is reported in the appendix to keep the main data section focused on measurement and the final analysis sample.

The dataset was constructed from heterogeneous broadcaster archives. The raw source materials consisted of 60 PDF documents comprising 10,638 pages, typically organized at the show-year level rather than as structured spreadsheets. These documents were split into episode-level files, converted into intermediate text records, and processed through a schema-based extraction workflow to generate standardized episode- and guest-level meta-data. Automated extraction was followed by extensive manual cleaning and validation. Guest names were standardized, duplicates were resolved, politician status was checked, and party affiliations were aligned over time. External sources, including Abgeordnetenwatch, Bundestag, European Parliament, state-politician, and government datasets, were used to validate politician status and add information on offices, mandates, constituency links, gender, age, and party-career histories. Ambiguous cases were reviewed manually, especially where archival labels, automated classifications, and external-source matches did not agree.

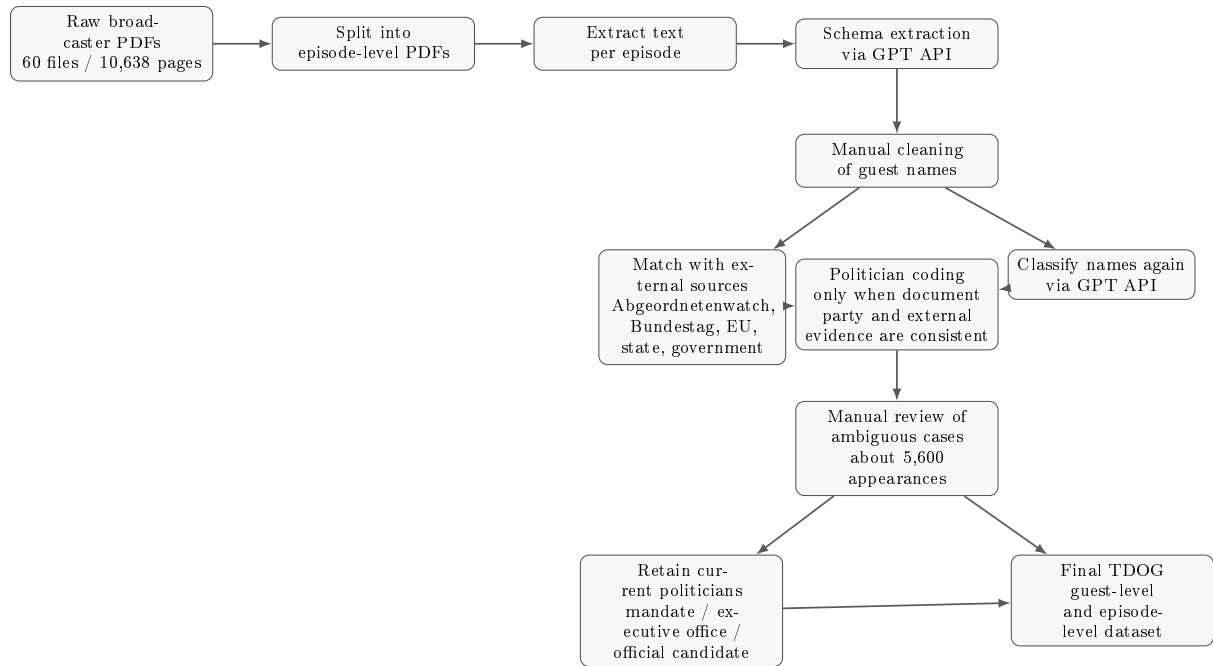


Figure A1: Data construction workflow for TDOG. The workflow converts heterogeneous broadcaster PDFs into standardized episode- and guest-level records, validates political classifications with external sources, and retains current political representatives and official candidates for the party-political analysis.

A.4 Party representation in talk-show appearances

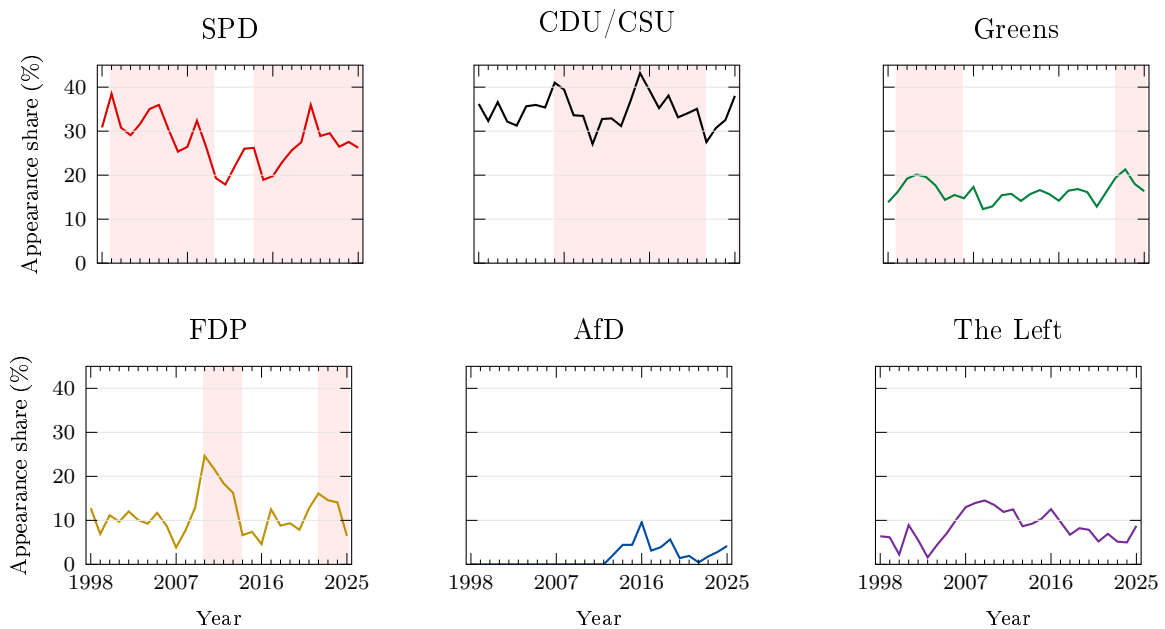
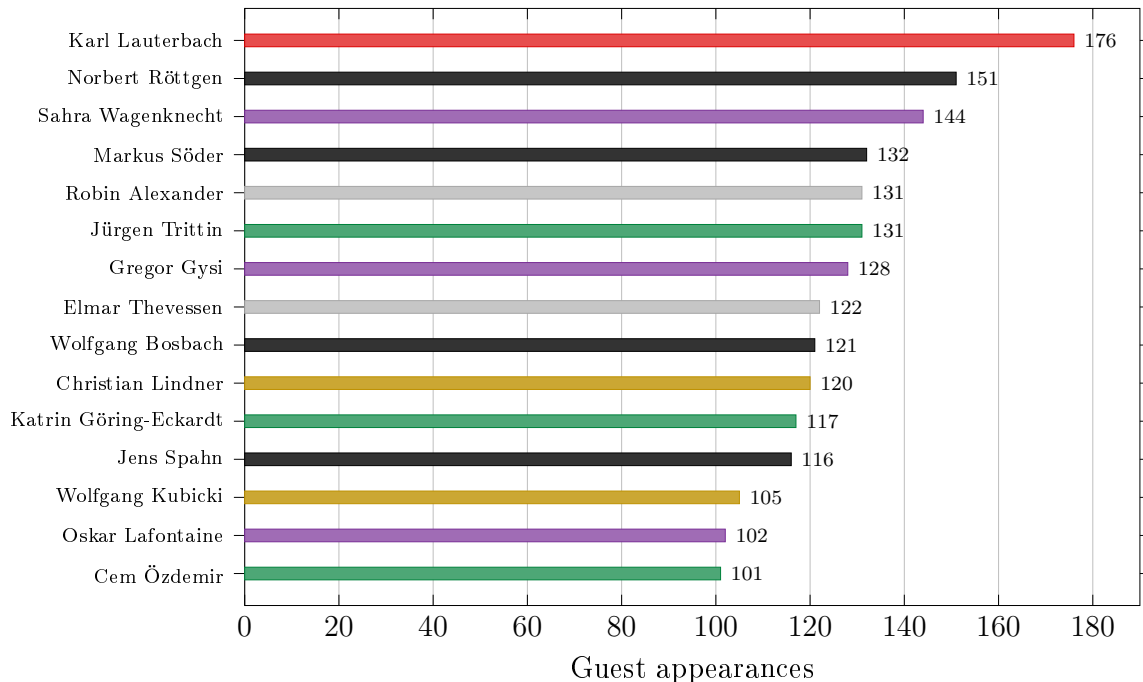


Figure A2: Relative party representation in talk-show appearances. Light red shading marks the exact periods of federal-government participation, beginning and ending at the respective dates of cabinet change.

A.4.1 Concentration among recurring guests

The distribution of access is also highly unequal across individuals. A small group of politicians and recurring commentators account for many appearances, while most guests appear much less often. Figure A3 reports the most frequent guests in the corpus.



Note: Bar colors indicate party affiliation: red = SPD, black = CDU/CSU, green = Greens, yellow = FDP, purple = the Left. Gray bars denote journalists or commentators without party-political classification in this figure.

Figure A3: Most frequent guests in the talk-show corpus.

A.5 Clustering by interview date

The empirical analysis combines repeated cross-sectional survey data with two-day event windows around televised political appearances. For each appearance, respondents interviewed on the broadcast day are compared with respondents interviewed on the following day. Different individuals are interviewed on each date, so the repeated cross-sectional structure alone does not mechanically determine the appropriate clustering dimension.

A natural choice in an event-based design is event-level clustering. For example, Le Pennec and Pons (2023) cluster at the debate level in a related study of televised political events and repeated cross-sectional surveys. The overlap sample in this application creates an additional dependence structure. It retains intersecting event windows, so the same original survey observation may appear multiple times in the estimation data: it may be used in different event stacks and, in the fully interacted party stack, across party equations. These rows are copies of one underlying survey observation rather than independent draws. Although event IDs still partition the rows of the stacked dataset, copies of the same original observation can be assigned to different event clusters. Conventional one-way event clustering allows arbitrary dependence within an event but does not accommodate this mechanically induced dependence across event clusters.

I therefore cluster the baseline standard errors by calendar interview date. Every original survey observation has exactly one interview date, and every copy created by the

overlap or party stack retains that date. Date clustering consequently keeps all mechanically dependent copies of an observation in the same cluster. It also permits arbitrary residual correlation among different respondents interviewed on the same day. This is substantively plausible because those respondents share a contemporaneous political, media, and survey environment. Formally, the variance estimator allows

$$\text{Cov}(u_{id}, u_{jd}) \neq 0$$

for respondents i and j interviewed on calendar date d . This dependence is especially relevant because treatment status is defined by interview timing relative to the televised appearance and identification uses high-frequency variation across adjacent dates.

This argument concerns inference rather than identification. A separate political event on the post-appearance day could affect vote intentions and confound the estimated appearance effect. Clustering cannot remove such omitted-variable bias. Event fixed effects absorb stable differences across appearances, but not shocks that change between the broadcast day and the following day. Interview-date fixed effects are not a general solution: in the non-overlap design they are perfectly collinear with the post indicator, while in the overlap design identification would remain only on dates that are simultaneously pre for some events and post for others. Date clustering therefore does not eliminate daily shocks; it allows observations collected under the same daily conditions to have correlated disturbances.

Date and event clustering address different, non-nested forms of dependence. Event clustering permits arbitrary correlation between the pre- and post-date observations belonging to the same appearance. Date clustering does not impose dependence across those two calendar dates. Conversely, date clustering accommodates correlation among all observations sharing a calendar date, including observations assigned to different event stacks and multiple copies of the same original response. Because overlapping event windows mechanically connect event stacks, distinct event clusters need not be independent. Calendar dates remain a unique clustering dimension for the underlying survey observations.

The clustering decision is also distinct from the estimand. The primary estimand is the average effect of the realized historical appearances satisfying the sample definition. The analysis observes the complete set of relevant appearances during the study period and does not primarily treat them as a random sample from a superpopulation of hypothetical future events. Event clustering is therefore not required solely because the identifying comparisons are organized around events. Under a sampling-based interpretation, the historical appearances may be treated as fixed while the number of surveyed respondents grows. Baseline date-clustered inference nevertheless allows a richer form of respondent-level dependence through the asymptotic approximation

$$G_D \rightarrow \infty,$$

where G_D denotes the number of calendar-date clusters. This is an asymptotic device for inference, not a substantive claim that the observed dates were randomly sampled from a population of dates. If the estimand instead generalized explicitly from the observed appearances to a broader population of possible events, an asymptotic sequence such as $G_E \rightarrow \infty$, where G_E is the number of event clusters, would become more natural and event-level uncertainty would deserve greater emphasis.

Overall, calendar interview date is the preferred clustering dimension because it accommodates dependence induced by overlapping event windows, keeps every copy of an

original survey observation within one cluster, and permits common disturbances among respondents exposed to the same daily political and media environment. The fully interacted stack reproduces the separately estimated party coefficients and supplies the cross-party covariance matrix required for inference on the equally weighted average. Table A2 shows that the central patterns for support, problem-solving competence, and economic expectations also survive event-level and two-way clustering, albeit with wider confidence intervals and correspondingly weaker precision for some party-specific estimates.

Table A2: Clustering sensitivity of the main outcomes

Estimate	Interview date	Party-appearance event	Two-way
<i>Panel A: Support for the appearing party</i>			
Equal-party average	0.138*** (0.034)	0.138*** (0.049)	0.138*** (0.048)
SPD	0.171*** (0.065)	0.171* (0.094)	0.171* (0.093)
CDU/CSU	0.043 (0.062)	0.043 (0.091)	0.043 (0.089)
Greens	-0.051 (0.076)	-0.051 (0.108)	-0.051 (0.108)
FDP	0.259*** (0.062)	0.259*** (0.089)	0.259*** (0.088)
AfD	0.301** (0.141)	0.301 (0.201)	0.301 (0.200)
Left	0.105 (0.071)	0.105 (0.101)	0.105 (0.101)
<i>Panel B: Best party to solve problems</i>			
Equal-party average	0.121*** (0.032)	0.121*** (0.046)	0.121*** (0.046)
SPD	0.052 (0.081)	0.052 (0.116)	0.052 (0.115)
CDU/CSU	0.290*** (0.090)	0.290** (0.131)	0.290** (0.129)
Greens	-0.029 (0.072)	-0.029 (0.104)	-0.029 (0.103)
FDP	-0.026 (0.049)	-0.026 (0.069)	-0.026 (0.069)
AfD	0.336*** (0.111)	0.336** (0.157)	0.336** (0.157)
Left	0.104** (0.052)	0.104 (0.075)	0.104 (0.074)
<i>Panel C: Economic-optimism score</i>			
Equal-party average	-0.459** (0.202)	-0.459* (0.254)	-0.459* (0.271)
SPD	-0.049 (0.220)	-0.049 (0.312)	-0.049 (0.311)
CDU/CSU	0.816*** (0.196)	0.816*** (0.287)	0.816*** (0.282)
Greens	0.390 (0.316)	0.390 (0.454)	0.390 (0.450)
FDP	0.658* (0.350)	0.658 (0.502)	0.658 (0.498)
AfD	-3.512*** (0.811)	-3.512*** (1.158)	-3.512*** (1.151)
Left	-1.057** (0.420)	-1.057* (0.592)	-1.057* (0.593)

Notes: Entries are coefficients with clustered standard errors in parentheses. Support and perceived problem-solving competence are measured in percentage points. The economic-optimism score equals improvement minus deterioration and is likewise scaled in percentage points. Within each row, the point estimate, estimation sample, respondent controls, co-presence controls, and event fixed effects are identical; only the variance estimator changes. The stacked samples contain 5,377,544 respondent–event observations for support, 3,679,431 for competence, and 3,225,398 for economic optimism. Across the six party equations, they comprise 4,089 interview-date clusters and 5,596 party-appearance-event clusters. The last column clusters two ways by interview date and party-appearance event. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.6 Timing checks

Table A3 reports the no-anticipation placebo discussed in the main text. It compares the day before the talk-show appearance to the talk-show day itself and includes the party, average, and political-bloc estimates corresponding to the main results. Figure A4 reports the party-specific event-study estimates corresponding to the equal-weighted average shown in Figure 4.

Table A3: No-anticipation placebos, $t = -1$ versus $t = 0$

Party or aggregate	Preferred specification
SPD	0.01 (0.07)
CDU/CSU	-0.01 (0.07)
Greens	0.09 (0.09)
FDP	0.04 (0.07)
AfD	0.07 (0.20)
Left	-0.10 (0.07)
Equal-weighted party average	0.015 (0.042)
Event-weighted average	0.065 (0.039)
<i>Aggregated bloc outcomes</i>	
Government bloc	-0.040 (0.063)
Opposition bloc	0.158** (0.074)
Left bloc	0.170*** (0.057)
Right bloc	-0.012 (0.058)

Notes: Cells report placebo percentage-point estimates defined as support on the day before the appearance minus support on the talk-show day, $Y_{-1} - Y_0$, in the preferred balanced overlap specification. Models include same-episode co-presence controls, respondent controls, and event fixed effects; standard errors are clustered by interview date and shown in parentheses. Bloc models control for same-episode presence of the counterpart bloc. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

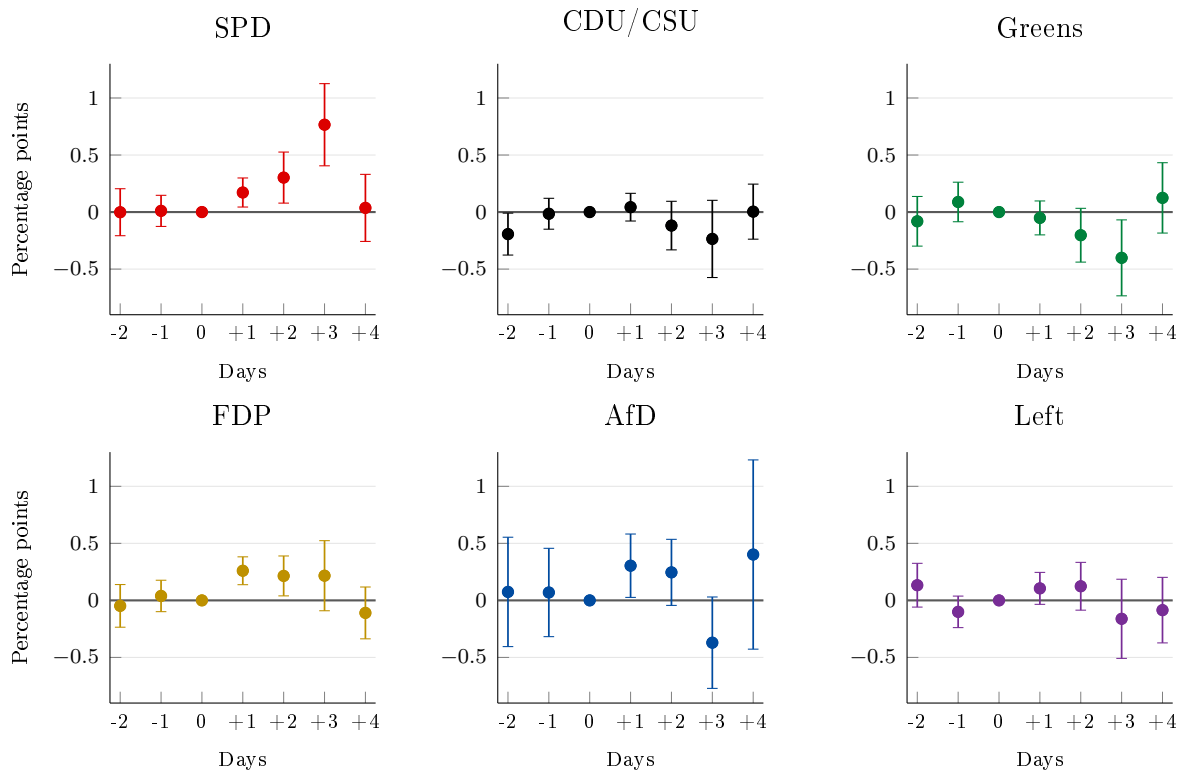


Figure A4: Party-specific event-study estimates for own-party support

Notes: Panels report party-specific, pairwise anchored comparisons from two days before to four days after an appearance, using the overlap specification with co-presence controls. The talk-show day ($t = 0$) is the reference category. Whiskers show 95 percent confidence intervals. Models include individual controls and event fixed effects, with standard errors clustered by interview date.

A.6.1 Comparison across horizon-specific dynamic estimators

This section provides the detailed specifications for the three alternative dynamic estimators used as robustness checks. For completeness and to make the notation directly comparable, it also states the anchored event-study specification underlying the main dynamic figure. The purpose is not to treat the models as interchangeable or to combine them into a single meta-estimate. Rather, the alternative estimators ask whether the short-run timing pattern is also visible under different aggregation and dynamic assumptions. Because the longest post-appearance horizon is four days, these estimates describe short-horizon dynamics rather than medium- or long-run effects.

Common setup and notation. All displayed specifications include co-presence controls. The outcome is support for the appearing party, measured in percentage points. The talk-show day is denoted by $t = 0$ and normalized to zero. Negative horizons are placebo leads, while positive horizons measure responses after the evening broadcast. Let i denote an individual respondent, e a party-talk-show event, p the focal party, c a pseudo-panel cohort based on previous vote, t a calendar day, and $r \in \mathcal{R} = \{-2, -1, 1, 2, 3, 4\}$ a relative horizon. X_i contains the individual controls used in the main analysis. C and Z denote co-presence, intermediate-appearance, weekday, and other specification-specific controls. A_{pt} is an indicator for at least one appearance by party p on calendar day t .

For each estimator m considered in this section, I construct the equal-party average of the six party-specific coefficients,

$$\widehat{\beta}_r^m = \frac{1}{6} \sum_{p=1}^6 \widehat{\beta}_{pr}^m, \quad m \in \{\text{ES, DL, ARDL, LP}\}. \quad (2)$$

The models differ in the unit of observation, the way persistence is handled, and the source of identifying variation. Consequently, the comparison is most informative for the sign, timing, and broad magnitude of the estimates, not for a formal equality test across models. Figure 5 displays only the three alternative estimators; the anchored event study is shown separately in Figure 4.

Anchored event study. The anchored event study is the closest extension of the main next-day design. For each party event e , party p , and relative day r , respondents interviewed on the talk-show day are compared with respondents interviewed on day $t_e + r$:

$$Y_{iepr} = \alpha_e + \beta_{pr}^{\text{ES}} \mathbf{1}\{t_i = t_e + r\} + X_i' \gamma + C_{epr}' \delta + \varepsilon_{iepr}. \quad (3)$$

Here, α_e denotes event fixed effects. The event set is anchored on appearances for which both $t = 0$ and $t = +1$ are observed, and the same event definition is retained at the other horizons. The controls C_{epr} account for same-episode co-presence on the talk-show day and appearances on intermediate days. Standard errors are clustered by interview date. This specification preserves the event-level comparison that underlies the main short-run estimate, but estimates each horizon separately.

Repeated-cross-section distributed-lag model. The distributed-lag model uses the full sequence of repeated daily cross-sections and estimates leads and lags simultaneously:

$$Y_{ipt} = \alpha_{w(t)} + X_i' \gamma + \sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \beta_{pr}^{\text{DL}} A_{p,t-r} + \sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \delta_{pr}^{\text{DL}} A_{-p,t-r} + \varepsilon_{ipt}. \quad (4)$$

$\alpha_{w(t)}$ denotes calendar-week fixed effects, and $A_{-p,t-r}$ controls for appearances by other major parties at the corresponding leads and lags. The model includes the individual controls, frequency weights from the compressed repeated-cross-section cells, and standard errors clustered by interview date. Unlike the anchored event study, every coefficient is estimated conditional on the other included leads and lags, so individual horizons can be sensitive to the selected dynamic window.

Pseudo-panel FE-ARDL model. The FE-ARDL specification aggregates the repeated cross-sections into daily previous-vote cohorts and explicitly models persistence in party support. Let $\bar{Y}_{cpt}$ denote average support for party p in cohort c on day t :

$$\bar{Y}_{cpt} = \rho_p \bar{Y}_{cp,t-1} + \alpha_c + \alpha_{w(t)} + \sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \beta_{pr}^{\text{ARDL}} A_{p,t-r} + \sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \delta_{pr}^{\text{ARDL}} A_{-p,t-r} + u_{cpt}. \quad (5)$$

Cohort fixed effects α_c absorb stable differences across previous-vote groups, and calendar-week fixed effects capture common time shocks. The regression is weighted by cohort-day cell size and clustered by date. The lagged dependent variable allows support to be persistent, but it can induce finite-panel bias in a fixed-effects model; the estimates are therefore treated as a robustness check rather than as a preferred replacement for the main event-level specification.

Local projections. Local projections estimate a separate regression for each horizon. Individual support is first adjusted for changes in survey composition and aggregated to party-day values. The horizon- r regression is

$$\tilde{Y}_{p,t+r} = \sum_q \beta_{qr}^{\text{LP}} \mathbf{1}\{p = q\} A_{q,t} + \sum_q \rho_{qr} \mathbf{1}\{p = q\} \tilde{Y}_{q,t} + C'_{ptr} \delta + \alpha_{p,w(t)} + \lambda_{p,\text{dow}(t+r)} + \nu_{ptr}. \quad (6)$$

$\tilde{Y}_{p,t+r}$ is composition-adjusted support for party p on the outcome day. The model controls for adjusted baseline support, same-day co-presence, and appearances on relevant intermediate days. Party-by-base-week and party-by-outcome-weekday fixed effects absorb common party-specific calendar patterns. Regressions are weighted by outcome-day cell size, and standard errors are clustered by outcome date. Local projections impose fewer restrictions on the shape of the response path, at the cost of lower precision at more distant horizons.

Interpretation. Figure 5 in the main text reports the three alternative dynamic estimators. At $t = +1$, all three produce positive point estimates: 0.059 percentage points in the repeated-cross-section distributed-lag model, 0.072 in the FE-ARDL model, and 0.050 in the local projections. The 95 percent confidence intervals exclude zero for the distributed-lag and FE-ARDL estimates, while the local-projection estimate is marginally significant. For reference, the anchored event study shown separately in Figure 4 also produces a positive next-day estimate of 0.139 percentage points.

At $t = +2$, the distributed-lag and FE-ARDL models remain positive and statistically precise, while the local-projection estimate is smaller and statistically imprecise. At $t = +3$, the distributed-lag estimate remains positive and precise, while the FE-ARDL and local-projection estimates are positive but imprecise. At $t = +4$, the estimates are -0.007 in the distributed-lag model, -0.007 in the FE-ARDL model, and -0.028 in the

local projections; all three confidence intervals include zero. The later horizons therefore do not support a stable effect that persists uniformly across the alternative specifications.

The placebo leads are also not uniformly identical across models. Most $t = -2$ and $t = -1$ confidence intervals include zero, but the local-projection estimate at $t = -2$ is negative and statistically distinguishable from zero at the 95 percent level. This pattern argues against describing the alternative models as mechanically confirming every feature of the main event study. A more accurate conclusion is that the positive next-day response is robust in sign across the three alternative estimators and statistically precise in several specifications, whereas evidence for both perfectly flat pre-trends and persistence beyond the first two post-appearance days is less uniform. Taken together, the models are most consistent with a short-lived attention or activation response concentrated immediately after the appearance, rather than a sustained medium-term shift in party support.

Party-specific dynamic counterfactuals. The main counterfactual applies the equal-weighted event-study coefficients to all parties. Figure A5 instead propagates the six separately estimated party response profiles through the same allocation and feedback mechanism. This specification preserves party heterogeneity but also recursively amplifies the greater sampling uncertainty of the individual coefficients.

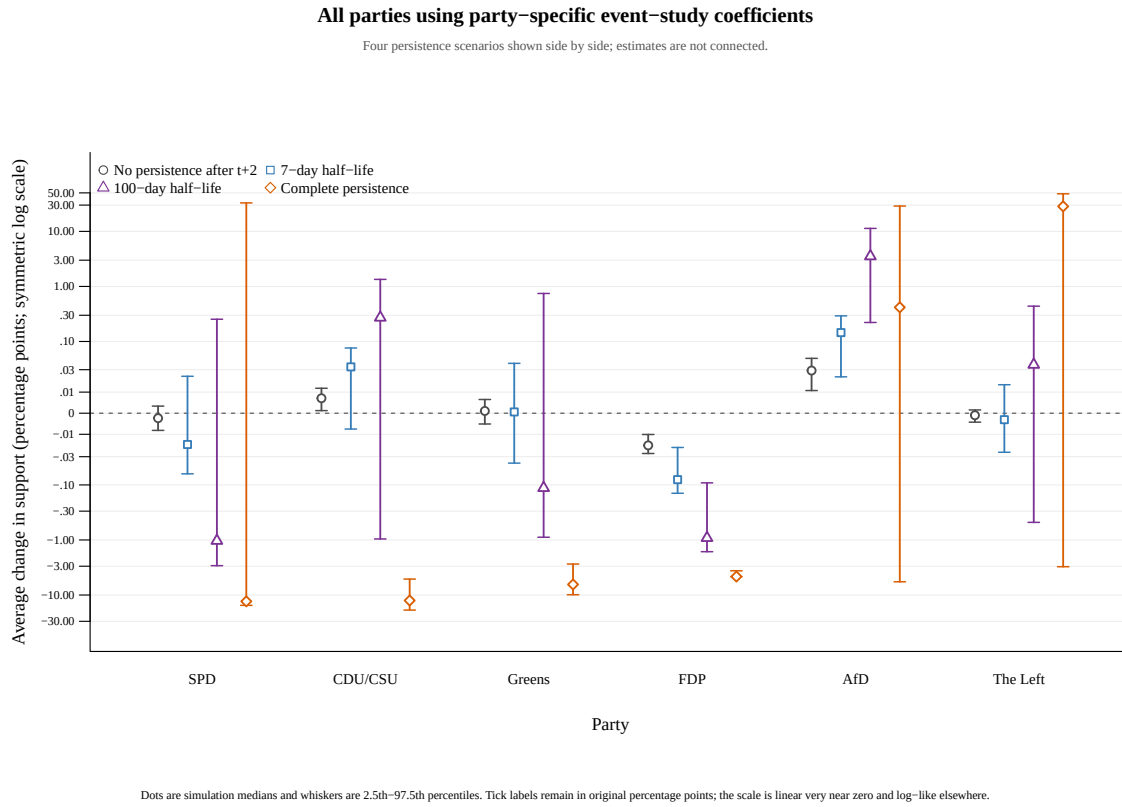


Figure A5: Party-specific dynamic visibility counterfactuals

Notes: Dots show simulation medians and whiskers show 95% simulation intervals. The symmetric log-like axis permits negative, zero, and positive changes while retaining visibility of both small and large estimates; tick labels are in the original percentage-point units. The scenarios assume no direct persistence beyond $t + 2$, a seven-day half-life, a 100-day half-life, and complete persistence. The strict and seven-day scenarios use 2,000 Monte Carlo draws; the 100-day and complete-persistence scenarios use 500. The allocation rule, 14-day polling window, seven-day invitation lag, and endogenous invitation feedback are otherwise held fixed.

A.7 Detailed economic-expectation tables

Figure 6 in the main text summarizes the preferred co-presence-adjusted estimates using the net-optimism score, with the Government and Opposition estimates appended at the right. Appendix Figure A6 reports the party-specific event-study profiles. Table A4 provides the category-specific results, Table A5 reports the government/opposition comparison, and Table A6 reports the common-sample attenuation check.

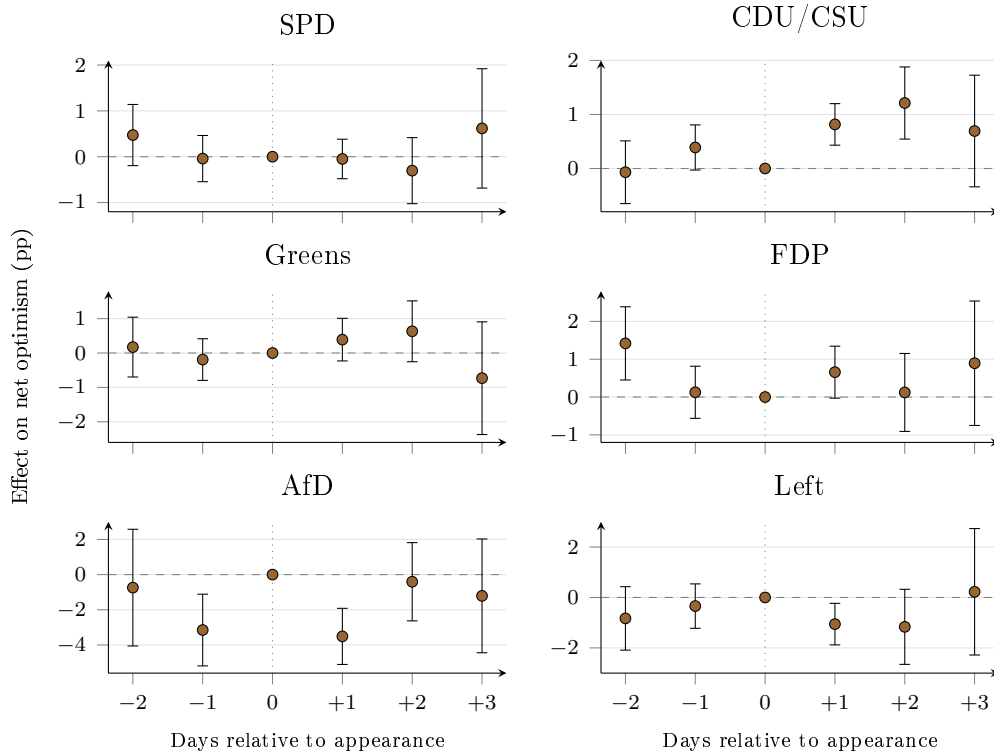


Figure A6: Party-specific event-study estimates for economic expectations

Notes: The outcome is the net-optimism score in percentage points, equal to the probability of expecting improvement minus the probability of expecting deterioration. Each horizon is estimated separately against the talk-show day ($t = 0$). Models include individual controls, event fixed effects, same-episode co-presence controls, and controls for party appearances on relevant intermediate days. Whiskers show party-specific 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered by interview date. Panel-specific vertical scales are used for readability.

Table A4: Party-specific economic-expectation effects in the preferred specification

Outcome	Party	Effect	N
Improve	SPD	-0.040 (0.121)	863,115
	CDU/CSU	0.541*** (0.103)	1,060,972
	Greens	0.203 (0.168)	548,298
	FDP	0.191 (0.182)	401,590
	AfD	-1.023** (0.465)	51,322
	Left	-0.493** (0.208)	300,101
Unchanged	SPD	0.031 (0.131)	863,115
	CDU/CSU	-0.266** (0.112)	1,060,972
	Greens	-0.016 (0.186)	548,298
	FDP	0.275 (0.194)	401,590
	AfD	-1.466** (0.639)	51,322
	Left	-0.072 (0.248)	300,101
Worsen	SPD	0.009 (0.135)	863,115
	CDU/CSU	-0.275** (0.122)	1,060,972
	Greens	-0.187 (0.197)	548,298
	FDP	-0.466** (0.217)	401,590
	AfD	2.489*** (0.565)	51,322
	Left	0.564** (0.275)	300,101

Notes: Cells report party-specific percentage-point effects on the three mutually exclusive economic-expectation outcomes in the preferred balanced overlap specification. Models include same-episode co-presence controls, respondent controls, and event fixed effects; standard errors are clustered by interview date and shown in parentheses. Since respondents choose one category, the three coefficients within a party sum to zero up to rounding. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A5: Government/opposition appearances and economic expectations

Outcome	Treatment	Effect	N
Optimism score (pp)	Post $\times$ government present	0.425*** (0.140)	1,596,440
	Post $\times$ opposition present	0.068 (0.161)	1,596,440
Improve, pp	Post $\times$ government present	0.320*** (0.075)	1,596,440
	Post $\times$ opposition present	0.011 (0.085)	1,596,440
Unchanged, pp	Post $\times$ government present	-0.215*** (0.083)	1,596,440
	Post $\times$ opposition present	0.045 (0.095)	1,596,440
Worsen, pp	Post $\times$ government present	-0.105 (0.088)	1,596,440
	Post $\times$ opposition present	-0.056 (0.101)	1,596,440

Notes: Preferred date-level $t = +1$ estimates on balanced overlap windows. All effects are percentage points; the optimism score equals Improve minus Worsen. Government and opposition presence enter jointly, so each serves as the other's co-presence control. Models include respondent controls and event fixed effects; interview-date-clustered standard errors are shown in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A6: Party-support estimates with and without economic expectations

Party	Baseline	+ optimism score	Change	N	Party-event dates
SPD	0.092 (0.089)	0.093 (0.089)	0.001	863,115	1,494
CDU/CSU	0.160** (0.082)	0.134 (0.082)	-0.027	1,060,972	1,835
Greens	-0.086 (0.093)	-0.089 (0.093)	-0.002	548,298	967
FDP	0.264*** (0.074)	0.264*** (0.074)	0.000	401,590	677
AfD	0.144 (0.214)	0.069 (0.216)	-0.075	51,322	131
Left	0.134 (0.090)	0.125 (0.089)	-0.009	300,101	492

Notes: Preferred overlap specification with co-presence controls and valid expectations. The second column adds the -1 to $+1$ optimism score; Change is controlled minus baseline. Standard errors are in parentheses. The adjustment is descriptive, not causal mediation. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.8 Economic pessimism and income heterogeneity

This section reports the estimates underlying the economic-grievance interpretation and its income-specific extensions. Table A7 reports the overall conditional relationship between expectations and support across all six parties. The remaining tables document the general income gradient in expectations and examine how the treatment and expectation–support relationships vary across income groups for the AfD and the Left. Because expectations and vote intentions are observed in the same interview, these associations do not establish causal ordering and are not interpreted as formal mediation.

Table A7: Economic expectations and party support across six parties

	SPD	CDU/CSU	Greens	FDP	AfD	Left
Expect economy to improve	2.753*** (0.076)	2.013*** (0.078)	-0.271*** (0.043)	-0.055* (0.033)	-0.654*** (0.045)	-0.495*** (0.025)
Expect economy to worsen	-3.647*** (0.059)	-3.493*** (0.072)	-0.961*** (0.038)	0.013 (0.028)	2.692*** (0.059)	0.945*** (0.027)
Net optimism score	6.400*** (0.090)	5.507*** (0.105)	0.689*** (0.043)	-0.068** (0.033)	-3.346*** (0.065)	-1.440*** (0.028)
Interview-date fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Date-clustered standard errors	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	2,307,891	2,307,891	2,307,891	2,307,891	631,251	2,307,891
Interview-date clusters	6,966	6,966	6,966	6,966	3,236	6,966
Survey years	1998–2025	1998–2025	1998–2025	1998–2025	2013–2025	1998–2025

Notes: Percentage-point coefficients; standard errors are in parentheses. Improve and Worsen use unchanged economic expectations as their reference category. The net-optimism score equals the Improve minus Worsen contrast and its standard error uses their within-model covariance. Controls are household income, sex, education, age, previous vote, state, and municipality size. Expectations and vote intention are measured contemporaneously, so the estimates are interpreted as conditional associations rather than causal effects. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A8: Household income and economic expectations

	Economy worsens (percentage points)	Expectation index (−1 to +1)
Income below 1,500 EUR	2.794*** (0.126)	-0.064*** (0.002)
Income 1,500–2,500 EUR	2.303*** (0.111)	-0.055*** (0.002)
Income 2,500–4,000 EUR	0.971*** (0.106)	-0.028*** (0.002)
Interview-date fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Respondent controls	Yes	Yes
Date-clustered standard errors	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,912,622	1,912,622
Interview-date clusters	6,967	6,967

Notes: The reference group is household income of 4,000 EUR or more. A lower expectation index denotes greater pessimism. Controls are sex, education, age, previous vote, state, and municipality size. All specifications include interview-date fixed effects. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A9: Net economic optimism and own-party support by household income

	AfD support	Left support
<i>One-unit increase in the net-optimism score</i>		
Below 1,500 EUR	-2.131*** (0.284)	-1.029*** (0.118)
1,500–2,500 EUR	-1.764*** (0.299)	-0.985*** (0.088)
2,500–4,000 EUR	-2.116*** (0.219)	-0.782*** (0.087)
4,000+ EUR	-2.471*** (0.244)	-0.796*** (0.084)
Interview-date fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Respondent controls	Yes	Yes
Date-clustered standard errors	Yes	Yes
Observations	51,322	300,101
Interview-date clusters	254	928

Notes: Percentage-point associations between the net-optimism score and own-party support. The score equals -1 for worsen, 0 for unchanged, and $+1$ for improve, so a negative coefficient means that a one-unit shift toward pessimism is associated with greater party support. Models use the party-specific overlap samples, include interview-date fixed effects and respondent controls, and cluster standard errors by interview date. Expectations and vote intentions are contemporaneous, so these coefficients are not interpreted causally. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A10: Effects of AfD and Left appearances on pessimistic expectations by income

Income group	AfD appearance	Left appearance
Below 1,500 EUR	3.641*** (1.042)	0.420 (0.394)
1,500–2,500 EUR	2.046** (0.849)	0.735* (0.376)
2,500–4,000 EUR	2.322*** (0.802)	0.551 (0.350)
4,000+ EUR	2.566*** (0.732)	0.048 (0.353)
Observations	51,322	300,101
Interview-date clusters	254	928

Notes: The outcome is the probability of expecting the economy to worsen, in percentage points. Cells report the overlap + co-presence specification. Standard errors are in parentheses. Models include event-by-income fixed effects, respondent controls, and party-specific co-presence controls; standard errors are clustered by interview date. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.9 Economic-expectation averages

The main text reports party-specific economic-expectation effects. Tables A11 and A12 report averages of the preferred balanced-overlap, co-presence-adjusted estimates, first including all parties and then excluding the AfD. These averages are descriptive summaries of the party-specific estimates rather than a substitute for the party-level patterns emphasized in the main text.

Table A11: Average economic-expectation effects across all parties

Outcome	Equal avg.	Event-weighted avg.	Events	N
Improve	-0.10	0.15	7,825	3,677,530
Unchanged	-0.23	-0.08	7,825	3,677,530
Worsen	0.33	-0.07	7,825	3,677,530

Table A12: Average economic-expectation effects excluding AfD

Outcome	Equal avg.	Event-weighted avg.	Events	N
Improve	0.08	0.18	7,667	3,625,743
Unchanged	-0.02	-0.05	7,667	3,625,743
Worsen	-0.06	-0.12	7,667	3,625,743

A.10 Supplementary heterogeneity evidence

The main text reports the next-day party-size gradient and focuses on income among respondent characteristics because income is directly integrated into the economic-pessimism mechanism assessment. This appendix reports the full horizon-specific party-size decomposition, the complete income results for all parties, and age, municipality-size, education, and gender splits as supplementary demographic checks.

A.10.1 Party-size decomposition

Table A13 decomposes pre-event party support into between-party and within-party components at every event-study horizon. The negative $t = +1$ between coefficient underlies the main-text result that generally smaller parties have larger estimated returns to appearances. The within coefficient at $t = +1$ is negative but imprecise. At later horizons both components become more negative, but the significant within-party moderation in the pre-period makes those later differences unsuitable as clean causal evidence of a size mechanism.

Table A13: Within- and between-party size moderation across event-study horizons

Relative day	Effect at event-sample mean	Within-party moderation	Between-party moderation
$t = -2$	-0.017 (0.053)	0.0184*** (0.0065)	0.0031 (0.0029)
$t = -1$	0.059 (0.040)	0.0111** (0.0056)	0.0026 (0.0024)
$t = +1$	0.092** (0.036)	-0.0056 (0.0051)	-0.0043** (0.0022)
$t = +2$	0.003 (0.058)	-0.0224*** (0.0078)	-0.0131*** (0.0031)
$t = +3$	-0.097 (0.091)	-0.0318*** (0.0094)	-0.0100** (0.0044)

Notes: Percentage-point estimates with interview-date clustered standard errors in parentheses. Moderation coefficients report the change in the estimated appearance effect associated with a one-percentage-point increase in support. Pre-event support is measured over days $t - 37$ through $t - 8$. The within component is the event-specific deviation from the party's event-sample mean; the between component is that party mean relative to the overall event-sample mean. Models include respondent controls, event fixed effects, co-presence controls, and intervening-appearance controls where applicable. The pooled size-moderation leads are jointly significant ($p = 0.047$), so the post-period gradients are interpreted descriptively. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.10.2 Income heterogeneity

The main text emphasizes the income patterns for the two most substantively important cases, the Left and the AfD. Figure A7 reports the corresponding 2×3 figure for all six parties using the preferred pooled overlap interaction specification with co-presence controls. Table A14 reports the underlying overlap estimates.

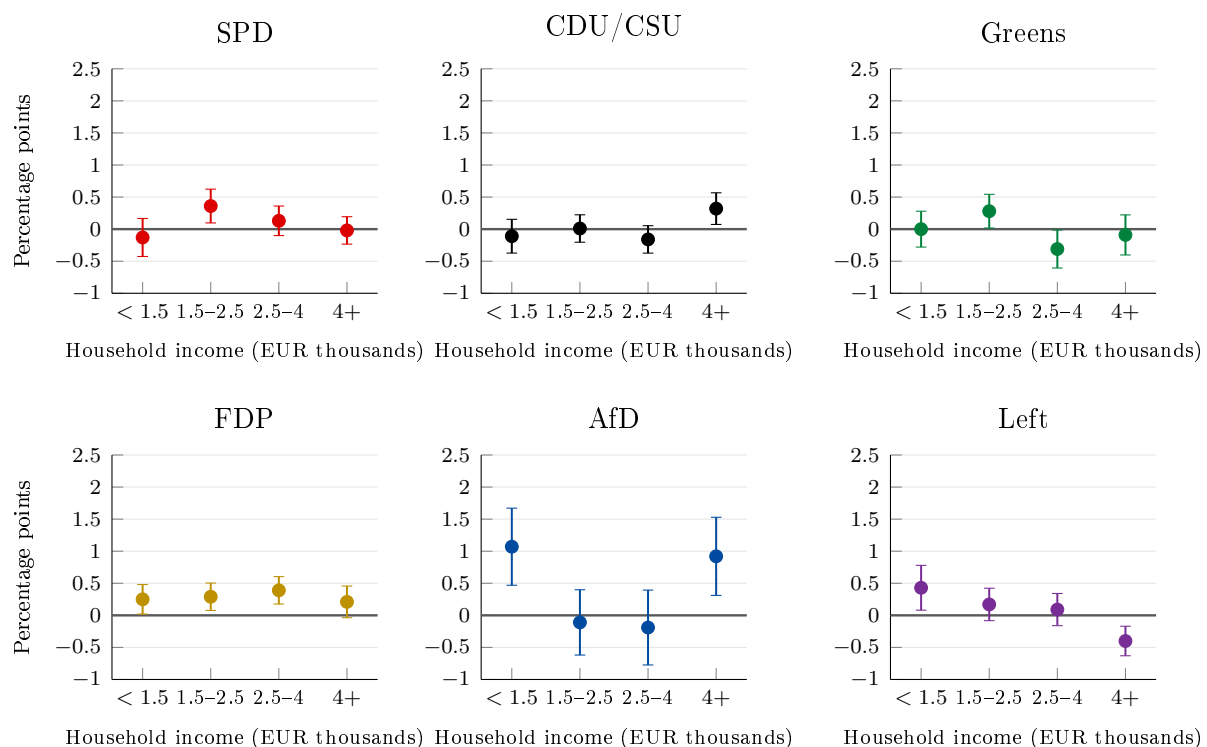


Figure A7: Income heterogeneity across six parties. The figure reports the preferred pooled interaction specification using balanced overlap events and co-presence controls. Whiskers show 90% confidence intervals.

Table A14: Income heterogeneity by four household-income groups

Group	Party	Overlap subgroup	Overlap interaction
<1500 EUR	SPD	-0.12 (0.18)	-0.08 (0.17)
	CDU/CSU	-0.09 (0.16)	-0.23 (0.16)
	Greens	0.03 (0.17)	0.14 (0.17)
	FDP	0.26* (0.14)	0.21 (0.14)
	AfD	1.27*** (0.42)	1.07*** (0.37)
	Left	0.43** (0.22)	0.43** (0.21)
1500-2500 EUR	SPD	0.36** (0.16)	0.25* (0.15)
	CDU/CSU	0.00 (0.13)	0.09 (0.13)
	Greens	0.27* (0.16)	0.23 (0.16)
	FDP	0.29** (0.13)	0.28** (0.12)
	AfD	-0.02 (0.32)	-0.11 (0.31)
	Left	0.14 (0.16)	0.17 (0.15)
2500-4000 EUR	SPD	0.14 (0.14)	0.16 (0.14)
	CDU/CSU	-0.16 (0.13)	-0.07 (0.13)
	Greens	-0.30* (0.18)	-0.33* (0.17)
	FDP	0.38*** (0.13)	0.42*** (0.12)
	AfD	-0.27 (0.35)	-0.19 (0.35)
	Left	0.14 (0.16)	0.09 (0.15)
4000+ EUR	SPD	-0.03 (0.13)	0.03 (0.13)
	CDU/CSU	0.32** (0.15)	0.32** (0.14)
	Greens	-0.07 (0.19)	-0.02 (0.19)
	FDP	0.21 (0.15)	0.21 (0.15)
	AfD	0.66** (0.32)	0.92** (0.37)
	Left	-0.27** (0.14)	-0.40*** (0.14)
<1500 EUR	Equal-weighted average	0.29	0.28
1500-2500 EUR	Equal-weighted average	0.17	0.17
2500-4000 EUR	Equal-weighted average	-0.01	-0.01
4000+ EUR	Equal-weighted average	0.14	0.13

Notes: Both columns use balanced overlap events and same-episode co-presence controls. The first column reports separate subgroup regressions; the second reports pooled interaction models with event-by-group fixed effects and co-presence controls interacted with income group. Respondent controls are included and standard errors are clustered by interview date. Average rows are descriptive equal-weighted averages across the six focal parties. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.10.3 Age and municipality-size heterogeneity

Tables A15 and A16 report the age and municipality-size estimates in the preferred balanced overlap design, using both separate subgroup regressions and pooled interaction models.

Table A15: Age heterogeneity with co-presence controls

Group	Party	Overlap subgroup	Overlap interaction
14-29	SPD	0.56*** (0.22)	0.55*** (0.21)
	CDU/CSU	-0.32 (0.21)	-0.32 (0.21)
	Greens	-0.25 (0.27)	-0.26 (0.27)
	FDP	0.42* (0.25)	0.31 (0.25)
	AfD	0.00 (0.48)	0.08 (0.47)
	Left	0.34 (0.23)	0.34 (0.22)
30-44	SPD	-0.14 (0.14)	-0.15 (0.14)
	CDU/CSU	0.27* (0.14)	0.28** (0.14)
	Greens	-0.37** (0.18)	-0.36** (0.17)
	FDP	0.64*** (0.15)	0.65*** (0.15)
	AfD	0.21 (0.36)	0.21 (0.35)
	Left	-0.03 (0.14)	-0.03 (0.14)
45-59	SPD	0.26** (0.13)	0.26** (0.13)
	CDU/CSU	0.04 (0.12)	0.05 (0.12)
	Greens	-0.06 (0.15)	-0.06 (0.15)
	FDP	0.11 (0.11)	0.12 (0.11)
	AfD	0.81** (0.34)	0.84** (0.34)
	Left	0.01 (0.15)	0.00 (0.15)
60+	SPD	0.29*** (0.11)	0.30*** (0.11)
	CDU/CSU	-0.05 (0.10)	-0.05 (0.10)
	Greens	0.16 (0.12)	0.16 (0.12)
	FDP	0.11 (0.10)	0.12 (0.10)
	AfD	0.12 (0.24)	0.10 (0.24)
	Left	0.29** (0.12)	0.29** (0.13)
14-29	Equal-weighted average	0.12	0.12
30-44	Equal-weighted average	0.10	0.10
45-59	Equal-weighted average	0.20	0.20
60+	Equal-weighted average	0.15	0.15

Notes: Both columns use balanced overlap events and same-episode co-presence controls. The first column reports separate subgroup regressions; the second reports pooled interaction models with event-by-group fixed effects and co-presence controls interacted with age group. Respondent controls are included and standard errors are clustered by interview date. Average rows are descriptive equal-weighted averages across the six focal parties. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A16: Municipality-size heterogeneity with co-presence controls

Group	Party	Overlap subgroup	Overlap interaction
Small: below 20,000	SPD	0.36*** (0.12)	0.35*** (0.12)
	CDU/CSU	0.14 (0.12)	0.14 (0.12)
	Greens	0.07 (0.13)	0.07 (0.13)
	FDP	0.40*** (0.12)	0.40*** (0.12)
	AfD	0.11 (0.26)	0.11 (0.26)
	Left	0.06 (0.11)	0.06 (0.11)
Medium: 20,000–99,999	SPD	0.19 (0.15)	0.19 (0.15)
	CDU/CSU	0.38*** (0.13)	0.38*** (0.13)
	Greens	-0.10 (0.16)	-0.10 (0.16)
	FDP	0.08 (0.12)	0.08 (0.12)
	AfD	1.02*** (0.34)	1.01*** (0.34)
	Left	-0.05 (0.14)	-0.04 (0.14)
Large: 100,000+	SPD	0.09 (0.14)	0.09 (0.14)
	CDU/CSU	-0.37*** (0.12)	-0.38*** (0.12)
	Greens	-0.49*** (0.16)	-0.51*** (0.16)
	FDP	0.35*** (0.12)	0.36*** (0.12)
	AfD	0.03 (0.25)	0.04 (0.25)
	Left	0.58*** (0.14)	0.59*** (0.14)
Small: below 20,000	Equal-weighted average	0.19	0.19
Medium: 20,000–99,999	Equal-weighted average	0.25	0.25
Large: 100,000+	Equal-weighted average	0.03	0.03

Notes: Both columns use balanced overlap events and same-episode co-presence controls. The first column reports separate subgroup regressions; the second reports pooled interaction models with event-by-group fixed effects and co-presence controls interacted with municipality-size group. Respondent controls are included and standard errors are clustered by interview date. Average rows are descriptive equal-weighted averages across the six focal parties. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.10.4 Education and gender heterogeneity with co-presence controls

Tables A17 and A18 report the corresponding education and gender heterogeneity estimates in the preferred balanced overlap design. Each table combines separate subgroup regressions with pooled interaction estimates that allow co-presence controls to vary by group. The education grouping aggregates the *forsa* education variable into four categories: lower/basic schooling, upper secondary, tertiary education, and other/unclear/student/missing.

Table A17: Education heterogeneity with co-presence controls

Group	Party	Overlap subgroup	Overlap interaction
Lower/basic schooling	SPD	0.14 (0.10)	0.14 (0.10)
	CDU/CSU	0.04 (0.09)	0.04 (0.09)
	Greens	0.06 (0.10)	0.07 (0.10)
	FDP	0.15 (0.09)	0.15* (0.09)
	AfD	0.45 (0.34)	0.44 (0.34)
	Left	0.21** (0.10)	0.21** (0.10)
Upper secondary	SPD	0.40*** (0.14)	0.39*** (0.14)
	CDU/CSU	-0.46*** (0.14)	-0.46*** (0.14)
	Greens	-0.06 (0.20)	-0.09 (0.20)
	FDP	0.75*** (0.15)	0.73*** (0.15)
	AfD	0.18 (0.23)	0.19 (0.24)
	Left	0.16 (0.16)	0.17 (0.16)
Tertiary	SPD	0.17 (0.12)	0.17 (0.12)
	CDU/CSU	0.35*** (0.12)	0.35*** (0.12)
	Greens	-0.43** (0.18)	-0.43** (0.18)
	FDP	0.11 (0.14)	0.11 (0.14)
	AfD	0.56** (0.26)	0.58** (0.26)
	Left	0.02 (0.15)	0.02 (0.15)
Other/unclear/student/missing	SPD	0.31 (0.53)	0.25 (0.52)
	CDU/CSU	0.71 (0.45)	0.72 (0.45)
	Greens	1.54** (0.63)	1.68*** (0.62)
	FDP	0.19 (0.54)	0.16 (0.53)
	AfD	-1.50* (0.90)	-1.47 (0.89)
	Left	-0.52 (0.46)	-0.50 (0.45)
Lower/basic schooling	Equal-weighted average	0.17	0.17
Upper secondary	Equal-weighted average	0.16	0.16
Tertiary	Equal-weighted average	0.13	0.13
Other/unclear/student/missing	Equal-weighted average	0.12	0.14

Notes: Both columns use balanced overlap events and same-episode co-presence controls.

Subgroup estimates come from separate regressions; interaction estimates come from pooled models with event-by-group fixed effects and co-presence controls interacted with education group. Respondent controls are included and standard errors are clustered by interview date. Average rows are descriptive equal-weighted averages across the six focal parties. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A18: Gender heterogeneity with co-presence controls

Group	Party	Overlap subgroup	Overlap interaction
Men	SPD	0.13 (0.10)	0.13 (0.10)
	CDU/CSU	0.04 (0.09)	0.04 (0.09)
	Greens	-0.14 (0.11)	-0.14 (0.11)
	FDP	0.40*** (0.10)	0.40*** (0.10)
	AfD	0.51** (0.24)	0.51** (0.25)
	Left	0.17 (0.11)	0.17 (0.11)
Women	SPD	0.31*** (0.09)	0.31*** (0.09)
	CDU/CSU	0.02 (0.09)	0.02 (0.09)
	Greens	0.00 (0.12)	0.00 (0.12)
	FDP	0.13 (0.08)	0.13 (0.08)
	AfD	0.21 (0.20)	0.21 (0.20)
	Left	0.11 (0.10)	0.11 (0.10)
Men	Equal-weighted average	0.18	0.18
Women	Equal-weighted average	0.13	0.13

Notes: Both columns use balanced overlap events and same-episode co-presence controls. Subgroup estimates come from separate regressions; interaction estimates come from pooled models with event-by-group fixed effects and co-presence controls interacted with gender. Respondent controls are included and standard errors are clustered by interview date. Average rows are descriptive equal-weighted averages across the six focal parties. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.11 Mechanism checks

The next tables report the two mechanism checks discussed at the end of the results section. Table A19 tests whether first or early appearances by politicians have especially large effects. Table A20 first contrasts former own-party voters with all other respondents, while Table A21 disaggregates the latter group by previous federal vote. The detailed estimates show that only the SPD exhibits a clear general pattern of reinforcement among former own-party voters; the sources of the other parties' estimated gains are more varied.

Table A19: Politician novelty and prior talk-show experience

Party	First appearance	Prior appearances	$\log(1 + \text{prior})$
SPD	0.08 (0.13)	0.00 (0.00)	-0.02 (0.03)
CDU/CSU	-0.07 (0.12)	0.00* (0.00)	-0.01 (0.03)
Greens	0.27* (0.16)	0.00 (0.00)	-0.03 (0.03)
FDP	-0.08 (0.10)	0.00** (0.00)	0.08*** (0.02)
AfD	0.21 (0.17)	-0.01 (0.01)	-0.06 (0.07)
Left	-0.10 (0.14)	0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.03)
Co-presence controls	✓	✓	✓
Individual controls	✓	✓	✓
Event fixed effects	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Preferred balanced overlap specification. Cells report coefficients on interactions between the post indicator and the respective politician-experience measure. The first column uses an indicator for whether the politician had no prior appearance for the same party in the talk-show corpus; this coefficient is therefore the difference between first and repeat appearances. The second and third columns use the number of prior appearances, respectively its log transformation. Standard errors are clustered by interview date and shown in parentheses. The linear prior-appearance interaction is reported with three decimals because it is measured per additional prior appearance. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Figure A8 reports an additional exploratory politician-level exercise for the five most frequent politicians within each party. These estimates are descriptive because recurring politicians are selected into talk shows, differ in the periods in which they appear, and often have wide confidence intervals.

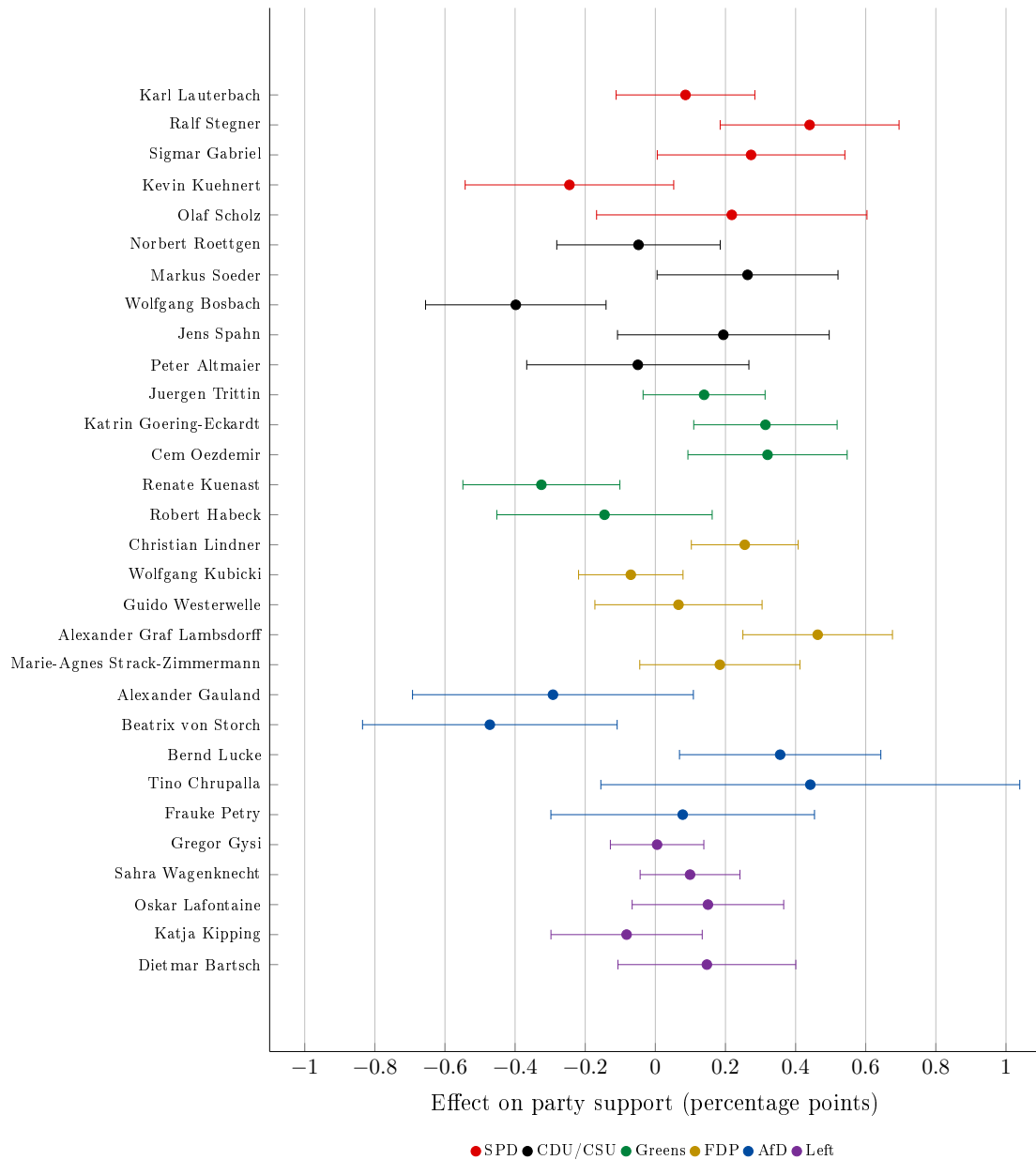


Figure A8: Exploratory top-five politician-specific effects on own-party support. Points are overlap-sample estimates for the five most frequent politicians within each party; horizontal bars show 90% confidence intervals.

Table A20: Reinforcement interaction tests

Party	Non-own previous vote	Own previous vote	Reinforcement gap
SPD	-0.01 (0.06)	0.81*** (0.20)	0.82*** (0.20)
CDU/CSU	0.12* (0.06)	-0.13 (0.15)	-0.24 (0.17)
Greens	-0.02 (0.07)	-0.21 (0.37)	-0.20 (0.37)
FDP	0.24*** (0.05)	0.55 (0.62)	0.31 (0.62)
AfD	0.24* (0.13)	1.97 (1.59)	1.74 (1.60)
Left	0.08 (0.06)	0.68 (0.87)	0.60 (0.87)

Notes: Preferred balanced overlap specification. Cells report percentage-point effects from pooled reinforcement interaction models. Non-own previous vote is the estimated post effect among respondents who did not report having voted for the appearing party in the previous federal election. Own previous vote is the corresponding effect among respondents who did report having voted for the appearing party. The reinforcement gap tests whether the two effects differ statistically. Models include same-episode co-presence controls, individual controls, and event fixed effects; standard errors are clustered by interview date and shown in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A21: Party-support effects by previous federal vote

Previous federal vote	Appearing party and support outcome					
	SPD	CDU/CSU	Greens	FDP	AfD	Left
SPD	0.81*** (0.20)	-0.01 (0.10)	0.13 (0.16)	0.17** (0.08)	-0.13 (0.25)	0.08 (0.15)
CDU/CSU	-0.04 (0.07)	-0.12 (0.15)	0.11 (0.11)	0.48*** (0.10)	-0.09 (0.29)	0.10* (0.06)
FDP	0.11 (0.17)	1.21*** (0.31)	0.43 (0.29)	0.55 (0.62)	0.69 (0.75)	0.00 (0.18)
Greens	-0.20 (0.14)	0.06 (0.11)	-0.21 (0.37)	-0.03 (0.09)	0.69*** (0.23)	-0.07 (0.22)
AfD	0.15 (0.16)	-0.18 (0.27)	-0.30* (0.18)	-0.27 (0.31)	1.98 (1.60)	0.08 (0.39)
Left	0.26 (0.23)	-0.09 (0.13)	-1.06*** (0.38)	0.23 (0.16)	-0.64 (0.62)	0.68 (0.87)
Did not vote	0.34 (0.23)	-0.11 (0.22)	-0.48** (0.21)	0.35** (0.17)	2.36*** (0.65)	0.37 (0.24)
Not eligible	0.45 (0.39)	0.53 (0.40)	0.39 (0.56)	-0.10 (0.37)	-0.25 (0.67)	-0.08 (0.43)
Other party	-0.01 (0.28)	0.36 (0.33)	0.16 (0.45)	0.23 (0.29)	-0.97 (1.27)	-0.25 (0.58)
Omnibus interaction p	0.002	0.007	0.018	0.056	< 0.001	0.945
BH-adjusted omnibus q	0.007	0.014	0.027	0.068	< 0.001	0.945

Notes: Cells report percentage-point effects of an appearance on support for the same party, separately by previous-vote category. Estimates come from pooled balanced-overlap interaction models with event-by-group fixed effects, respondent controls, and same-episode co-presence controls interacted with previous-vote group. Standard errors clustered by interview date are shown in parentheses. The omnibus row tests equality of the nine group effects within each party; the final row applies a Benjamini–Hochberg correction across the six omnibus tests. Cell-level stars test each group effect against zero and are not tests of differences between groups. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.11.1 Ideological origins of party-support responses

Tables A22 and A23 formalize the two decompositions discussed in Section 5.6. The first table groups respondents by their previous federal vote and compares the estimated response among voters from the same ideological side as the appearing party with the response among voters from the opposite side. Panel A retains previous voters of the appearing party and therefore combines reinforcement with persuasion. Panel B excludes them and compares only respondents who previously supported another party. The second table instead aggregates current party-support outcomes and tests whether support falls more among other parties on the same side or among parties on the opposite side between the talk-show day and the following day.

Table A22: Party-support responses by the ideological bloc of previous vote

Party	Same-side effect	Opposite-side effect	Same – opposite	Respondent–event obs.	Events
<i>Panel A: All previous voters</i>					
SPD	0.464*** (0.146)	-0.004 (0.060)	0.468*** (0.155)	1,325,200	1,494
CDU/CSU	0.022 (0.143)	0.012 (0.069)	0.010 (0.159)	1,626,298	1,835
Greens	0.001 (0.196)	0.119 (0.093)	-0.118 (0.215)	857,768	967
FDP	0.232 (0.153)	0.107* (0.058)	0.125 (0.163)	601,372	677
AfD	-0.198 (0.394)	0.120 (0.146)	-0.318 (0.408)	117,032	131
Left	-0.011 (0.211)	0.124* (0.064)	-0.134 (0.220)	435,247	492
<i>Panel B: Previous voters of the appearing party excluded</i>					
SPD	-0.086 (0.124)	0.014 (0.058)	-0.100 (0.135)	971,346	1,494
CDU/CSU	0.738*** (0.235)	0.010 (0.069)	0.728*** (0.241)	1,108,560	1,835
Greens	-0.060 (0.146)	0.147 (0.090)	-0.208 (0.172)	744,284	967
FDP	0.444*** (0.097)	0.119** (0.057)	0.325*** (0.110)	561,577	677
AfD	0.023 (0.275)	0.084 (0.144)	-0.061 (0.317)	112,656	131
Left	0.046 (0.120)	0.094* (0.057)	-0.048 (0.135)	413,309	492

Notes: Percentage-point effects from preferred balanced-overlap models. The same-side category is defined by the appearing party: SPD, Greens, and the Left form the left bloc; CDU/CSU, FDP, and AfD form the right bloc. Models include event-by-previous-vote-bloc fixed effects, respondent controls, and previous-vote-bloc-specific same-episode co-presence controls. Standard errors are clustered by interview date and shown in parentheses. Panel B removes respondents who previously voted for the appearing party, so its same-side estimates capture voters of ideologically adjacent parties rather than previous own-party voters. The difference column uses the full within-model covariance matrix. The SPD difference in Panel A and the CDU/CSU and FDP differences in Panel B remain significant after a Benjamini–Hochberg adjustment across the six party-specific contrasts within each panel ($q = 0.015$, $q = 0.010$, and $q = 0.010$, respectively). *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

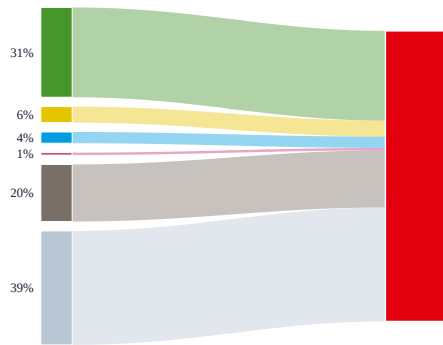
Table A23: Changes in current support for same-side and opposite-side parties

Appearing party	Other same-side parties	Opposite-side parties	Donor contrast	Respondent–event obs.	Events
SPD	-0.081 (0.066)	0.060 (0.076)	0.141 (0.115)	1,435,076	1,494
CDU/CSU	0.016 (0.046)	0.009 (0.067)	-0.007 (0.087)	1,762,769	1,835
Greens	-0.002 (0.097)	-0.048 (0.106)	-0.046 (0.162)	928,559	967
FDP	-0.112 (0.119)	0.002 (0.125)	0.114 (0.200)	650,971	677
AfD	0.074 (0.271)	0.246 (0.312)	0.172 (0.520)	126,948	131
Left	-0.316** (0.151)	0.225 (0.150)	0.541** (0.248)	473,221	492

Notes: Percentage-point changes from the talk-show day to the following day in the preferred balanced-overlap specification. “Other same-side parties” excludes the appearing party itself. The donor contrast equals the coefficient for opposite-side support minus the coefficient for support of other same-side parties; a positive value therefore indicates a larger decline among ideologically adjacent parties. Models include event fixed effects, respondent controls, and same-episode co-presence controls, with standard errors clustered by interview date. These are aggregate repeated-cross-section changes, not observed individual transitions. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Figures A9–A14 place the two descriptive decompositions side by side for each party. In every figure, the left panel proportionally allocates negative cross-party current-support coefficients to the appearing party’s estimated own-party gain. The right panel reports positive composition-weighted contributions from the previous-vote interaction model; negative contributions are omitted. The left-hand allocation is undefined for the Greens because their estimated own-party effect is negative. These figures summarize point estimates and do not replace the formal contrast tests in Tables A22 and A23.

(a) Current-support allocation



(b) Previous-vote contributions

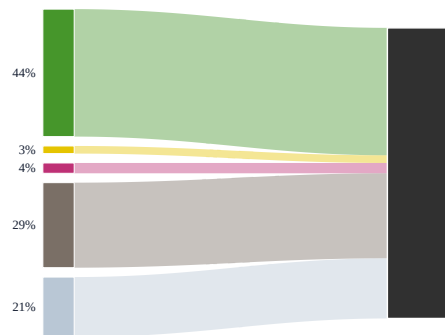


■ SPD ■ CDU/CSU ■ Greens ■ FDP ■ AfD ■ The Left ■ Other party
■ Did not vote ■ Unknown

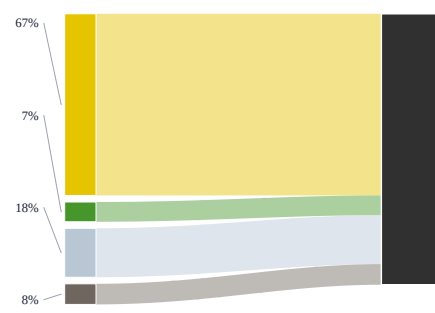
Figure A9: Estimated sources of the SPD support response.

Notes: Numbers on the left of each panel report absolute percentage shares and sum to 100 percent apart from rounding. Panel (a) proportionally allocates negative current-support coefficients to the appearing party's estimated own-party gain. Panel (b) decomposes the total of positive composition-weighted contributions from previous-vote groups; negative contributions are omitted. The light-gray category is labeled "Unknown." Both panels summarize aggregate repeated-cross-section estimates at $t + 1$ relative to the talk-show day and do not represent observed individual transitions. If the own-party point estimate is non-positive, a gain-source allocation is undefined and panel (a) reports this instead of imposing an artificial inflow.

(a) Current-support allocation



(b) Previous-vote contributions



■ SPD ■ CDU/CSU ■ Greens ■ FDP ■ AfD ■ The Left ■ Other party
■ Did not vote ■ Unknown

Figure A10: Estimated sources of the CDU/CSU support response.

Notes: Numbers on the left of each panel report absolute percentage shares and sum to 100 percent apart from rounding. Panel (a) proportionally allocates negative current-support coefficients to the appearing party's estimated own-party gain. Panel (b) decomposes the total of positive composition-weighted contributions from previous-vote groups; negative contributions are omitted. The light-gray category is labeled "Unknown." Both panels summarize aggregate repeated-cross-section estimates at $t + 1$ relative to the talk-show day and do not represent observed individual transitions. If the own-party point estimate is non-positive, a gain-source allocation is undefined and panel (a) reports this instead of imposing an artificial inflow.

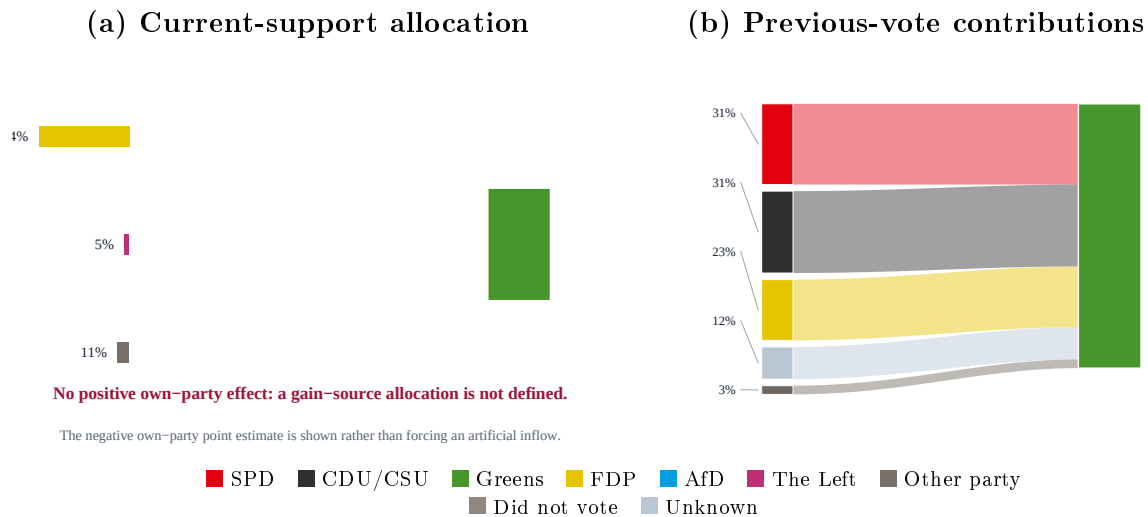
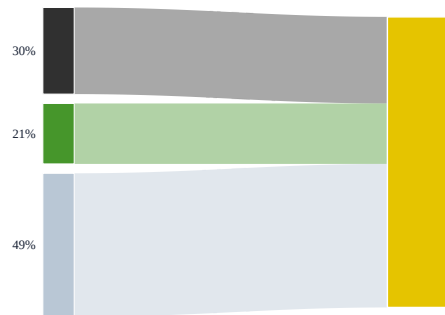


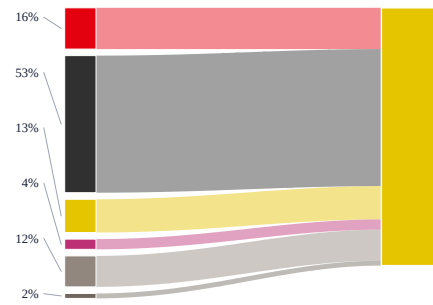
Figure A11: Estimated sources of the Green support response.

Notes: Numbers on the left of each panel report absolute percentage shares and sum to 100 percent apart from rounding. Panel (a) proportionally allocates negative current-support coefficients to the appearing party's estimated own-party gain. Panel (b) decomposes the total of positive composition-weighted contributions from previous-vote groups; negative contributions are omitted. The light-gray category is labeled "Unknown." Both panels summarize aggregate repeated-cross-section estimates at $t + 1$ relative to the talk-show day and do not represent observed individual transitions. If the own-party point estimate is non-positive, a gain-source allocation is undefined and panel (a) reports this instead of imposing an artificial inflow.

(a) Current-support allocation



(b) Previous-vote contributions

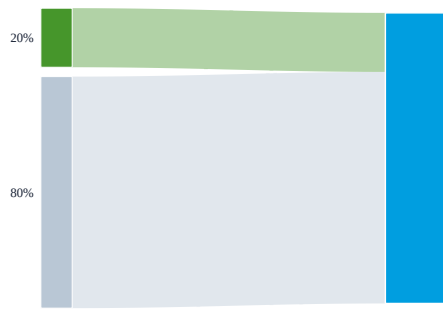


■ SPD ■ CDU/CSU ■ Greens ■ FDP ■ AfD ■ The Left ■ Other party
■ Did not vote ■ Unknown

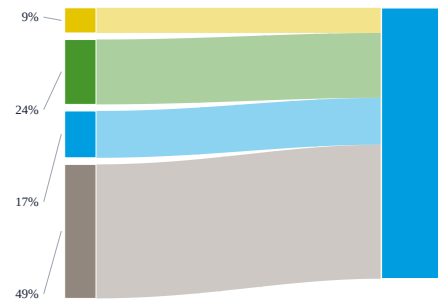
Figure A12: Estimated sources of the FDP support response.

Notes: Numbers on the left of each panel report absolute percentage shares and sum to 100 percent apart from rounding. Panel (a) proportionally allocates negative current-support coefficients to the appearing party's estimated own-party gain. Panel (b) decomposes the total of positive composition-weighted contributions from previous-vote groups; negative contributions are omitted. The light-gray category is labeled "Unknown." Both panels summarize aggregate repeated-cross-section estimates at $t + 1$ relative to the talk-show day and do not represent observed individual transitions. If the own-party point estimate is non-positive, a gain-source allocation is undefined and panel (a) reports this instead of imposing an artificial inflow.

(a) Current-support allocation



(b) Previous-vote contributions

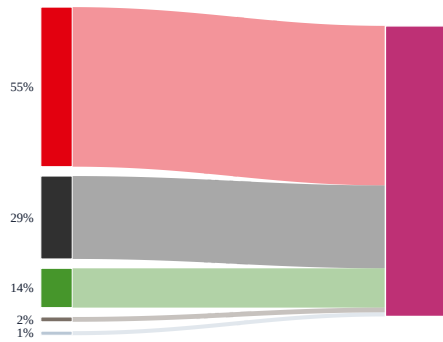


■ SPD
 ■ CDU/CSU
 ■ Greens
 ■ FDP
 ■ AfD
 ■ The Left
 ■ Other party
 ■ Did not vote
 ■ Unknown

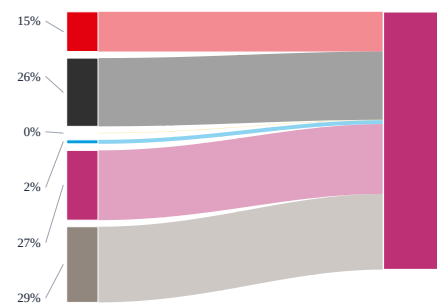
Figure A13: Estimated sources of the AfD support response.

Notes: Numbers on the left of each panel report absolute percentage shares and sum to 100 percent apart from rounding. Panel (a) proportionally allocates negative current-support coefficients to the appearing party's estimated own-party gain. Panel (b) decomposes the total of positive composition-weighted contributions from previous-vote groups; negative contributions are omitted. The light-gray category is labeled "Unknown." Both panels summarize aggregate repeated-cross-section estimates at $t + 1$ relative to the talk-show day and do not represent observed individual transitions. If the own-party point estimate is non-positive, a gain-source allocation is undefined and panel (a) reports this instead of imposing an artificial inflow.

(a) Current-support allocation



(b) Previous-vote contributions



■ SPD ■ CDU/CSU ■ Greens ■ FDP ■ AfD ■ The Left ■ Other party
■ Did not vote ■ Unknown

Figure A14: Estimated sources of the Left support response.

Notes: Numbers on the left of each panel report absolute percentage shares and sum to 100 percent apart from rounding. Panel (a) proportionally allocates negative current-support coefficients to the appearing party's estimated own-party gain. Panel (b) decomposes the total of positive composition-weighted contributions from previous-vote groups; negative contributions are omitted. The light-gray category is labeled "Unknown." Both panels summarize aggregate repeated-cross-section estimates at $t + 1$ relative to the talk-show day and do not represent observed individual transitions. If the own-party point estimate is non-positive, a gain-source allocation is undefined and panel (a) reports this instead of imposing an artificial inflow.

A.12 Government and opposition status

Table A24: Talk-show effects by government and opposition status

Party	Opposition	Government	Gov. – Opp.
SPD	0.18 (0.19)	0.18** (0.07)	0.00 (0.21)
CDU/CSU	-0.18 (0.14)	0.13* (0.07)	0.31** (0.15)
Greens	-0.03 (0.10)	-0.10 (0.13)	-0.07 (0.16)
FDP	0.34*** (0.09)	0.20** (0.08)	-0.14 (0.12)
AfD	0.30** (0.14)	–	–
Left	0.11 (0.07)	–	–

Notes: Preferred balanced overlap specification. Cells report percentage-point estimates separately for appearances made while the party was in federal opposition and while it was in federal government. The government-minus-opposition column reports the within-party difference. AfD and the Left have no federal-government observations in the sample period. Models include same-episode co-presence controls, respondent controls, and event fixed effects; standard errors are clustered by interview date and shown in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A25: Bloc-level government and opposition visibility effects

Outcome and appearance bloc	Effect
Government support after government appearance	0.10* (0.06)
Opposition support after opposition appearance	0.04 (0.07)

Notes: Cells report percentage-point effects from preferred balanced-overlap bloc-level $t = +1$ regressions. The government outcome equals support for any currently governing focal party, and the opposition outcome equals support for any currently opposition focal party. Each regression controls for the other bloc's same-episode presence, includes respondent controls and event fixed effects, and clusters standard errors by interview date. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.13 Additional respondent-group checks

These tables report additional interaction-based respondent-group checks. They complement the main income, age, and municipality-size heterogeneity tables.

Table A26: East/West heterogeneity

Group	Party	Effect	N
West Germany	SPD	0.16** (0.07)	1,435,076
	CDU/CSU	0.02 (0.07)	1,762,769
	Greens	-0.04 (0.09)	928,559
	FDP	0.26*** (0.07)	650,971
	AfD	0.25 (0.17)	126,948
	Left	0.20*** (0.07)	473,221
East Germany	SPD	0.22 (0.15)	1,435,076
	CDU/CSU	0.20 (0.15)	1,762,769
	Greens	-0.11 (0.15)	928,559
	FDP	0.25** (0.13)	650,971
	AfD	0.57 (0.49)	126,948
	Left	-0.33 (0.26)	473,221

Table A27: Employment heterogeneity

Group	Party	Effect	N
Employed	SPD	0.10 (0.08)	1,434,648
	CDU/CSU	0.10 (0.08)	1,762,268

Group	Party	Effect	N
	Greens	-0.20* (0.11)	928,291
	FDP	0.29*** (0.08)	650,781
	AfD	0.60*** (0.18)	126,925
	Left	0.09 (0.09)	473,083
Not employed	SPD	0.26** (0.11)	1,434,648
	CDU/CSU	-0.05 (0.10)	1,762,268
	Greens	0.16 (0.11)	928,291
	FDP	0.19** (0.09)	650,781
	AfD	-0.18 (0.23)	126,925
	Left	0.09 (0.12)	473,083
Missing / unknown	SPD	2.06 (1.80)	1,434,648
	CDU/CSU	-4.28** (1.83)	1,762,268
	Greens	8.16*** (2.23)	928,291
	FDP	5.85*** (2.00)	650,781
	AfD	3.01 (2.03)	126,925
	Left	3.65** (1.58)	473,083

Table A28: Union-household heterogeneity

Group	Party	Effect	N
Respondent is member	SPD	-0.02 (0.21)	1,435,063
	CDU/CSU	-0.08 (0.17)	1,762,756
	Greens	0.29 (0.24)	928,549
	FDP	0.30** (0.15)	650,965
	AfD	0.09 (0.39)	126,947
	Left	-0.15 (0.26)	473,217
Other household member	SPD	0.01 (0.30)	1,435,063
	CDU/CSU	-0.13 (0.28)	1,762,756
	Greens	-0.02 (0.37)	928,549
	FDP	1.13*** (0.24)	650,965
	AfD	0.43 (0.66)	126,947
	Left	0.38 (0.34)	473,217
Respondent and other member	SPD	0.66 (0.50)	1,435,063
	CDU/CSU	0.46 (0.38)	1,762,756
	Greens	0.08 (0.55)	928,549
	FDP	0.13 (0.32)	650,965
	AfD	-0.24 (1.24)	126,947
	Left	0.42 (0.64)	473,217
No household member	SPD	0.21*** (0.07)	1,435,063
	CDU/CSU	0.08 (0.07)	1,762,756
	Greens	-0.09 (0.09)	928,549
	FDP	0.19*** (0.07)	650,965
	AfD	0.39** (0.16)	126,947
	Left	0.12 (0.08)	473,217
Missing / unknown	SPD	-0.10 (0.52)	1,435,063
	CDU/CSU	-0.69 (0.46)	1,762,756
	Greens	-0.23 (0.53)	928,549
	FDP	0.43 (0.29)	650,965
	AfD	-0.51 (1.48)	126,947
	Left	0.08 (0.68)	473,217

Notes: Cells report percentage-point effects from the preferred balanced-overlap interaction models, with standard errors in parentheses. Each model interacts same-episode co-presence controls with the respondent group, includes respondent controls and event-by-group fixed effects, and clusters standard errors by interview date. N is the respondent–event observation count for the party-specific model and therefore repeats across groups within a party. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.14 Bloc and polarization checks

These checks summarize broader bloc-level and polarization patterns. The pooled effects are mostly small, while some period-specific estimates are larger and should be read as exploratory.

Table A29: Left vs right: support for left bloc

Period	Appearance treatment	Effect	N
Pooled	Left bloc present	0.069 (0.053)	2,656,118
	Right bloc present	0.006 (0.054)	2,656,118
1998–2002	Left bloc present	0.805*** (0.285)	135,592
	Right bloc present	-0.804*** (0.300)	135,592
2003–2007	Left bloc present	-0.151 (0.151)	390,747
	Right bloc present	0.304** (0.152)	390,747
2008–2012	Left bloc present	0.131 (0.137)	426,473
	Right bloc present	-0.235* (0.137)	426,473
2013–2017	Left bloc present	0.131 (0.116)	574,688
	Right bloc present	0.015 (0.117)	574,688
2018–2022	Left bloc present	0.092 (0.088)	734,925
	Right bloc present	-0.001 (0.092)	734,925
2023–2025	Left bloc present	-0.125 (0.138)	393,693
	Right bloc present	0.211 (0.137)	393,693

Table A30: Left vs right: support for right bloc

Period	Appearance treatment	Effect	N
Pooled	Left bloc present	-0.041 (0.052)	2,656,118
	Right bloc present	0.086 (0.053)	2,656,118
1998–2002	Left bloc present	0.236 (0.226)	135,592
	Right bloc present	-0.072 (0.242)	135,592
2003–2007	Left bloc present	-0.007 (0.122)	390,747
	Right bloc present	-0.043 (0.129)	390,747
2008–2012	Left bloc present	-0.289** (0.132)	426,473
	Right bloc present	0.358*** (0.133)	426,473
2013–2017	Left bloc present	-0.197* (0.114)	574,688
	Right bloc present	0.055 (0.114)	574,688
2018–2022	Left bloc present	0.138 (0.090)	734,925
	Right bloc present	-0.022 (0.098)	734,925
2023–2025	Left bloc present	-0.046 (0.156)	393,693
	Right bloc present	0.176 (0.152)	393,693

Table A31: Center vs edges: support for center bloc

Period	Appearance treatment	Effect	N
Pooled	Center bloc present	0.121*** (0.035)	2,656,118
	Edge bloc present	-0.131 (0.080)	2,656,118
1998–2002	Center bloc present	0.211 (0.165)	135,592
	Edge bloc present	0.570 (0.479)	135,592
2003–2007	Center bloc present	0.068 (0.089)	390,747
	Edge bloc present	-0.062 (0.246)	390,747
2008–2012	Center bloc present	0.058 (0.096)	426,473
	Edge bloc present	-0.216 (0.192)	426,473
2013–2017	Center bloc present	0.083 (0.077)	574,688
	Edge bloc present	-0.125 (0.149)	574,688
2018–2022	Center bloc present	0.170*** (0.062)	734,925
	Edge bloc present	-0.249 (0.164)	734,925
2023–2025	Center bloc present	0.113 (0.085)	393,693
	Edge bloc present	0.074 (0.199)	393,693

Table A32: Center vs edges: support for edge bloc

Period	Appearance treatment	Effect	N
Pooled	Center bloc present	-0.027 (0.019)	2,656,118
	Edge bloc present	0.105** (0.050)	2,656,118
1998–2002	Center bloc present	-0.043 (0.050)	135,592
	Edge bloc present	0.051 (0.125)	135,592
2003–2007	Center bloc present	-0.016 (0.029)	390,747
	Edge bloc present	-0.017 (0.108)	390,747
2008–2012	Center bloc present	-0.094** (0.040)	426,473
	Edge bloc present	0.099 (0.090)	426,473
2013–2017	Center bloc present	-0.111** (0.048)	574,688
	Edge bloc present	0.198* (0.103)	574,688
2018–2022	Center bloc present	0.031 (0.039)	734,925
	Edge bloc present	0.060 (0.109)	734,925
2023–2025	Center bloc present	0.037 (0.059)	393,693
	Edge bloc present	0.098 (0.154)	393,693

Notes: Cells report percentage-point coefficients from preferred balanced date-level overlap regressions, with interview-date clustered standard errors in parentheses. The two appearance blocs enter jointly in every model, so each is the other's same-date co-presence control. Models also include respondent controls and event fixed effects. *N* reports respondent–event observations. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.15 Yearly party effects on AfD support since 2013

These year-by-year estimates are exploratory. They are useful for checking whether the AfD-support effects vary around specific periods, but the many yearly tests should not be read as a single confirmatory trend test.

Table A33: Party appearance effects on AfD support, preferred balanced overlap

Year	SPD	CDU/CSU	Greens	FDP	AfD	Left	N
2013	-0.064	-0.100	-0.015	0.067	0.278*	-0.105	125,303
2014	-0.152	-0.031	0.323**	-0.113	0.383*	0.320	112,646
2015	-0.031	0.171	-0.135	-0.053	0.152	-0.189	119,389
2016	-0.205	0.238	-0.599***	-0.043	0.028	0.102	111,072
2017	0.187	-0.322**	0.123	-0.042	-0.353	0.677***	106,278
2018	0.009	-0.006	-0.060	0.314**	-0.194	0.156	132,470
2019	-0.183	0.229*	0.015	-0.338*	0.303	0.111	128,296
2020	-0.018	-0.090	0.120	-0.112	-0.803**	0.513***	149,214
2021	0.285***	-0.163**	-0.066	-0.006	0.244	-0.130	168,907
2022	-0.097	0.026	-0.053	0.325***	-0.280	-0.321**	156,038
2023	-0.295*	0.048	0.292*	0.313*	-0.383	0.153	152,540
2024	-0.079	0.105	-0.105	0.281**	0.271	-0.072	151,252
2025	0.002	-0.128	-0.281	-0.239	0.113	0.387	89,901

Notes: Cells are percentage-point coefficients from year-specific balanced date-level regressions. All six party-presence indicators enter jointly, so same-date co-presence is controlled directly. Models include respondent controls and event fixed effects; standard errors are clustered by interview date. *N* reports respondent–event observations. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A.16 Cross-party and AfD-specific supplementary checks

The final appendix checks examine cross-party spillovers and report additional AfD-specific evidence. Table A34 provides the detailed pairwise interpretation of how AfD support responds to AfD appearances across previous-vote groups. Table A35 asks whether an appearance by one party is followed by changes in support for any of the other five parties. These checks are reported as descriptive extensions because the main text focuses on own-party effects and on the broader economic-expectations and heterogeneity patterns.

Table A34: AfD support after AfD appearances by previous vote

Previous federal vote	Effect
SPD	-0.13 (0.25)
CDU/CSU	-0.09 (0.29)
FDP	0.69 (0.75)
Greens	0.69*** (0.23)
AfD	1.98 (1.60)
Left	-0.64 (0.62)
Did not vote	2.36*** (0.65)
Not eligible	-0.25 (0.67)
Other party	-0.97 (1.27)

Notes: Cells report percentage-point effects of AfD appearances on AfD support by previous-vote category in the preferred pooled balanced-overlap interaction specification. Each reported group effect is a linear combination tested against zero; SPD is merely the omitted category used to parameterize the interaction model. In targeted pairwise comparisons, the prior-non-voter effect is larger than the effects for SPD, CDU/CSU, Greens, the Left, respondents not previously eligible, and other-party voters after a Benjamini–Hochberg correction across the eight comparisons, but is not statistically distinguishable from the effects for former AfD and FDP voters. The model includes event-by-group fixed effects, same-episode co-presence controls interacted with previous-vote group, and respondent controls. Standard errors are clustered by interview date and shown in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A35: Cross-party appearance effects on party support

Appearing party	Party-support outcome					
	SPD	CDU/CSU	Greens	FDP	AfD	Left
SPD	–	0.084 (0.070)	-0.079 (0.058)	-0.014 (0.039)	-0.010 (0.030)	-0.002 (0.035)
CDU/CSU	0.073 (0.060)	–	-0.059 (0.048)	-0.004 (0.037)	0.019 (0.028)	-0.005 (0.030)
Greens	0.006 (0.094)	0.072 (0.097)	–	-0.147** (0.057)	0.026 (0.045)	-0.008 (0.050)
FDP	0.027 (0.110)	-0.119 (0.121)	-0.083 (0.090)	–	0.007 (0.045)	0.058 (0.052)
AfD	0.068 (0.290)	0.021 (0.299)	-0.183 (0.286)	0.053 (0.122)	–	0.361*** (0.133)
Left	-0.253* (0.135)	-0.132 (0.144)	-0.062 (0.116)	0.281***† (0.074)	0.075 (0.061)	–

Notes: Rows identify the appearing party and columns the party-support outcome. The 30 off-diagonal cells report percentage-point effects from separate preferred balanced-overlap regressions; diagonal own-party effects are reported in the main analysis. Every model includes same-episode co-presence controls for all other focal parties, respondent controls, and event fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by interview date are shown in parentheses. Cell-level stars use unadjusted p -values. The dagger marks the only estimate that remains significant at the 5% level after a Benjamini–Hochberg correction across all 30 coefficients ($q = 0.005$). The AfD-to-Left and Greens-to-FDP estimates have adjusted q -values of 0.103 and 0.104, respectively. Because the data are repeated cross-sections, the estimates describe aggregate support changes rather than individual transitions between parties. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.